the magazine for
the contemporary teacher

TEACHER PLUS

November 2025

Azim Premji University

RNI No: APENG/2003/09403

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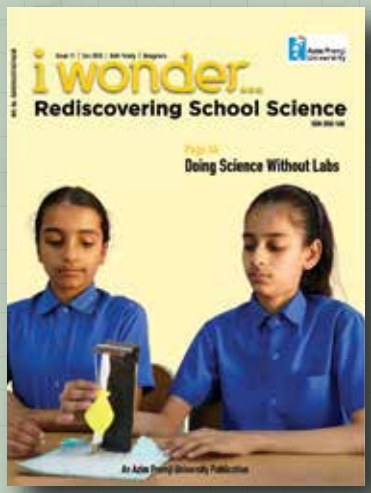

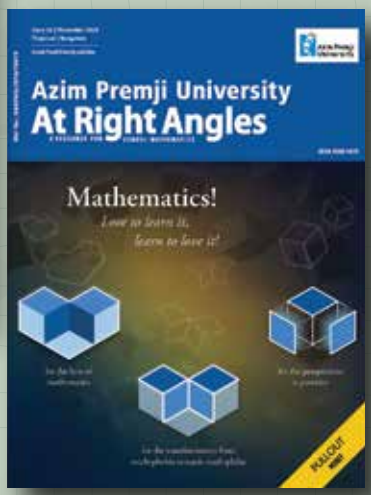

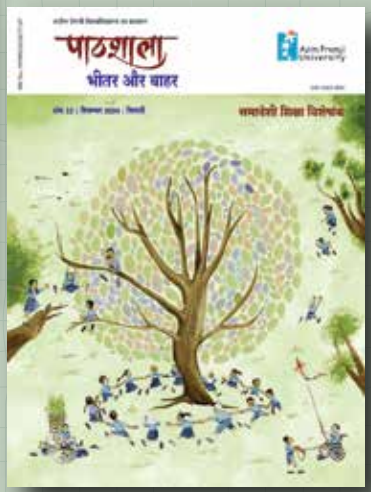

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Teacher Plus is supported by Azim Premji University

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Registered with the Registrar of Newspapers of India under RNI No: APENG/2003/09403

Unsolicited submissions are welcome. Please address all correspondence to
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ISSN No 0973-778

Vol. 23, No. 11; Pages 56

Cover: The ring of fire...and ice

Shweta Bindu Allam is a multidisciplinary designer, illustrator, psychologist, and foundational neuroscientist interested in how people perceive and connect with the world. Her work explores the subtle narratives hidden in small things and everyday places. Through visual storytelling, she aims to create experiences that feel both thoughtful and human. She can be reached at <shweta8allam@gmail.com>.

The rewards come later

If there's one thing teachers must learn to accept as part of the job, it's delayed gratification. And maybe that's too big a word to use for the little rewards that we come by, days, months, and even years later. But when those moments come, they do bring a warm glow to the heart and make up for the hours of what seems at times to be the routine drudgery of our everyday lives.

Many years ago, fuelled by a sense of total irritation with a group of students who had failed to take a deadline seriously, I dashed off (what I thought was) a sharply written note telling them what awaited them in the "real world" where such tardiness would not be excused nor tolerated, and warning them about the consequences of not attending to detail in substance and presentation. My general exasperation with their casual attitude to class assignments led me to throw in some general advice about the uncompromising nature of workplace expectations. I hit "send" on the email and waited, expecting some contrite apologies to trickle in. Even 24 hours later, not one from the group of 23 had acknowledged the email, let alone responded to it with something like an apology. *Youngsters these days*, I thought to myself, and put the incident behind me.

Five years later, a note popped into my inbox, from a sender whose name seemed familiar, but whose address looked associated with a distant foreign university. I opened it, anticipating a request for a letter of recommendation or some such. But no, it was a response to that email from all those years ago. This former student had just got a teaching job at a university overseas, and for some strange reason he decided to revisit that email from me. Reading it, he said, was like going through an orientation session before he embarked on his first job, and he was finally able to understand and see the relevance of what I had wanted to convey.

Often in the pages of *Teacher Plus* (or now, as you school through the website) we find accounts from individuals – some of them teachers – of how they went in a certain direction based on what they had heard from a teacher in primary school. Or how a lesson that went over their heads in a math class suddenly made sense years later, when they were in a situation where the principle was applied. Our effectiveness as teachers is almost always measured by performance in examinations, but we know that marks are not the best indicator of understanding, and that often takes years to gauge – and usually, we are not around to see the penny drop. It's rare that we even hear directly about whether and how we have impacted learning. But when we do, the warmth of satisfaction is palpable.

Usha Raman

Bringing stories to life

Engaging young minds through storytelling

Usha Rani Ravela

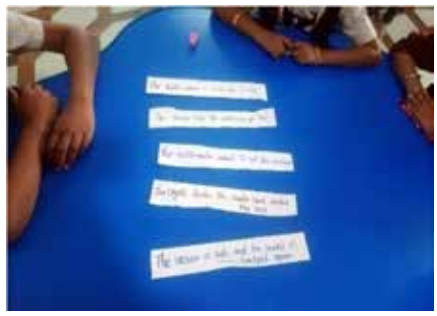
As a primary educator, I have always been fascinated by the power of storytelling in shaping young minds. Storytelling is not just about narrating events; it is an immersive experience that allows children to connect, imagine, and retain concepts for the long run. This became evident to me when I introduced storytelling through role play, sequencing, and story mapping in my class. The results were profound – not only did the children engage deeply with the stories, they also demonstrated a remarkable ability to recall and interpret them in their own unique ways.

Photos courtesy: Usha Rani Ravela

Activity overview

To make storytelling more interactive and meaningful, I used a combination of three strategies:

1. **Role play:** Children acted out different characters, helping them embody the emotions and actions of the story.
2. **Sequencing:** We used picture cards to arrange story events in order, reinforcing the logical flow.
3. **Story mapping:** Children created visual representations of the story, linking characters, settings, and key events.



For one of our sessions, I narrated a simple story about a clever mouse escaping danger. As I told the story, the children eagerly took on roles – some pretended to be the tiny, nervous mouse, others hissed like the rattlesnake, and a few played the fast-running coyote. They laughed, expressed different emotions, and even added their own ideas to make the story more exciting.

After the role play, we moved to sequencing, where the children arranged illustrated flashcards to match the story's events. This step helped them understand how a story flows from beginning to end. Finally, through story mapping, they drew their own versions of the adventure, adding personal touches that reflected their unique interpretations.

Insights and observations

What struck me most was how engaged the children were. The mix of movement, visuals, and storytelling made the experience unforgettable. Days later, when I asked them to retell the story, they remembered all the details and even added creative twists. One child imagined the mouse tricking many animals, while another described the snake learning a lesson and becoming kinder.

This experience reinforced an important lesson: storytelling is not about passive listening but about active exploration. Just like children's artworks reflect their thoughts and emotions, their engagement with stories reveals their unique perspectives. Their versions may not always match the original, but they carry deep personal meaning.

Why it's important to use interactive storytelling

Engaging children through storytelling techniques aligns with research on early learning. According to Wells (1986), "Children construct meaning through interaction, not just observation." This means that the more they engage with a story through different senses – movement, visuals, and discussion – the better they understand and retain it.

Loris Malaguzzi, founder of the Reggio Emilia approach, beautifully stated: "Children have a hundred languages, and a hundred more to think, to play, to speak..."

Storytelling allows children to use these 'languages' – acting, drawing, speaking, and imagining – to express their understanding. Encouraging these diverse expressions fosters confidence, creativity, and deeper connections with the learning material.

The Importance of open interpretation

Much like abstract drawings in children's art, storytelling does not have to be rigidly structured. What may seem like a simple story to an adult can hold layers of meaning for a child. By allowing them to explore, re-imagine, and retell stories in their own ways, we honour their perspectives and thought processes.

As educators, we must approach storytelling with curiosity rather than correction, encouraging children to share their interpretations without the fear of being 'wrong.' Open-ended questions such as "What do you think happened next?" or "Why do you think the bird felt that way?" allow children to dive deeper into their imaginations and express their ideas freely.

Conclusion

Storytelling, when enriched with interactive strategies, becomes more than just an academic exercise – it becomes a gateway into a child's thoughts, emotions, and creativity. The difference in how children and adults perceive a story isn't a gap to be bridged, but an opportunity to celebrate diverse perspectives.

By embracing role play, sequencing, and story mapping, we create a learning environment where children feel empowered to express, imagine, and remember. Their stories may take unexpected turns, but in those twists and deviations, we find the magic of their boundless creativity.

Usha Rani Ravela is an enthusiastic educator with 20 years of teaching experience. An Innovative Ambassador for Design Thinking and Innovation by the Ministry of Education, she has conducted webinars on pedagogy and assessment. Through creative methods, she helps children gain confidence and believe in their abilities. She can be reached at <usharaniravela20@gmail.com>.

From fire to ice

How competitions shape us and how they can heal us

Kalpana Sharma

For some students, competitions unlock confidence and skills textbooks rarely teach. This is what I believed once upon a time as a student and then as a teacher in the formative years of my teaching. I would be very prompt and active and grab every opportunity to prepare my students to stand out in various competitions. Looking back now, after a decade at a Krishnamurti school, I sometimes laugh at myself. What marathon was I running? It felt like an obsession – chasing crowns one after another, never satisfied. And yet, many of my students remain grateful for that ride.

"I was terrified of public speaking until I participated in the State level debate competition. Now I can argue my point in front of 200 people without shaking," recalls Vasu Bhardwaj, a class 10 student, 2005, BSN Shimla.

Others describe competitions as their first encounter with global issues.

"Representing BSN at the National Children's Science Congress in Sikkim made me read about environmental agreements for the first time. It felt like real-world learning," says Preetinder Singh, class 10, 2000.

Here, the enrichment is clear: critical thinking, teamwork, and curiosity flourish.

The prestige pressure

But for many, the story is different. Schools often handpick a small group of "competition stars" and pour resources into their success. This is exactly what I was doing.

"It felt like we weren't representing ourselves – we were representing the school's reputation. Winning mattered more than learning," says Saurav Verma, class 9, 2004, BSN Shimla.

Students also feel excluded.

"Unless you were already a topper or had polished English, you never got chosen. Most of us never even knew when the Olympiad sign-ups happened," shares a student from my previous school.

Photos courtesy: Kalpana Sharma

This raises the question: are competitions really for the students or for the school brochure? This is exactly what urges me to question the approach I was living with in my formative teaching years.

Inequality at play

Access is another issue. Private schools can hire debate coaches and send students to international MUNs. Government schools often can't. This realization came when I was interacting with my caretaker's son studying in a senior class in a government school.

> *"When we finally went for a quiz contest, the other team had custom jackets and coaches. We had no practice and nothing to rely on,"* says Lovely, class 9, from a government school.

Such disparities make "merit" look more like privilege.

The wellbeing question

Even for those who get in, the pressure can be crushing.

> *"I pulled three months before the State Level Quiz. I didn't care about anything else. My only focus was winning the crown,"* says Kulvinder, class 10.

Some thrive under this intensity. But others burn out or feel invisible when their school values only winners.

A way forward

Competitions don't have to be either enriching or performative. They can be both – if schools change how they approach them. Opening participation beyond the "star students," valuing effort over trophies, and connecting events back to classroom learning can ensure all students benefit. Once, a student of mine told me, *"I don't mind if the school posts our photos on social media or we get the news coverage, but I wish they cared as much about the kids who didn't win as the ones who did."*

An eye-opener

My perspective shifted most profoundly during a cultural exchange at Rajghat Besant School, Varanasi. Selected by SEEDS Asia, two schools from India interacted with two from Japan on the theme of sustainability.

What struck me was the ease with which the Japanese students participated. They questioned and answered spontaneously, always in groups, listening to one another and supporting each other. There was no identity crisis, no one-upmanship. The thrust was on learning together.

I was so moved by the approach that I started to read about various educational models across the globe. Sharing a few here:

Japan: Group effort and belonging

Japan's educational approach revolves around group effort and belonging. School life is built around **bukatsu** (after-school clubs), where collective perseverance (*ganbaru*) matters more than victory. As educator Tsunesaburo Makiguchi noted: *"Education is not to prepare for success, but to create value in life."* Yet, Japan also faces the shadow of **juken jigoku** ("examination hell"), where relentless test preparation overshadows joy.

Session at Loreto Convent, Tara Hall, Shimla.

Finland: Equity over competition
Finland, often ranked among the world's best systems, avoids high-stakes testing and inter-school competitions. Equity, trust, and student wellbeing take precedence. After reading the book, *Teach like Finland*, I gathered that the emphasis there is not to prepare children to be the best in the world, but to prepare them to be the best for the world. Here, enrichment is measured not by trophies but by how inclusive and stress-free learning remains.

Reggio Emilia and Summerhill: Children as agents
The Reggio Emilia approach in Italy treats children as co-constructors of knowledge. Projects emerge from curiosity and collaboration; learning is visible but not ranked.

In England, A.S. Neill's Summerhill School pushes this further with democratic, non-compulsory classes. Competitions are irrelevant because choice and joy, not achievement, are the goal. Neill insisted: *"The function of the child is to live his own life – not the life that his anxious parents think he should live."*

Fire and ice: education's balance
All this has made me pause. And I have translated this into my question: *Why have I been educated? What am I doing as a teacher?*

I happen to be from the hills, and we are all aware of the recent disasters in the mountain areas of our country. This summer when I visited my hometown, a sad thought overpowered me after seeing things withering away all around. Cement construction everywhere, deep scars left by the fury of nature. In spite of all this, everyone seemed comfortable with this "new normal," continuing in the race of winning.

The first thing I did was visit my alma mater. I asked the principal to give me a slot to interact with the senior grade students, where I wished to explore this question with them. Together, we began reflecting on the difference between studying only for marks, medals, and glories versus learning for something deeper.

During the session, we dipped further to evolve our **Ikigai**. *Ikigai*, a Japanese concept, simply means "a reason for being." It lies at the intersection of four guiding questions:

- What do I love to do?
- What am I good at?
- What does the world need?
- What can I be paid for?

When children and teachers started mapping their thoughts on these questions, it became a powerful moment. They could begin to understand and even question the true purpose of being educated.

Further into the sessions, I began a discussion on Robert Frost's *Fire and Ice*. The poem is simple on the surface – fire as desire, ice as hatred – but when I asked, *"What are we really being educated for?"* the group fell silent.

Are we being trained only to win debates, hackathons, MUNs, and Olympiads – to showcase brilliance and bring prestige to our schools? Or are we being educated to confront the realities that shape our future: climate change, wars, displacement, and disasters?

I had to help students and teachers understand that Frost's metaphors are no longer just poetic. Rising global temperatures are quite literally "fire." Melting polar ice caps are not just "ice" but the collapse of ecosystems. Hatred, intolerance, and violence fuel wars that students read about daily in the news.

In that moment, something powerful flowed. The group began to see that education cannot be reduced to medals or certificates. The reflection that emerged was this: The real purpose of learning is not performance for prestige but preparation for responsibility – to think critically, to care deeply, and to act wisely in a fractured world.

Competitions might sharpen skills, but if they do not help students ask the right questions – *What do my choices mean for the planet? How does my voice counter hatred? How can I act with empathy when disasters strike?* – Then education risks becoming ornamental rather than transformative.

So the challenge remains: Do our school events and classrooms prepare us for the headlines we will inherit, or are we being educated only to decorate report cards?

As Frost suggests, the world may end in fire or in ice. But perhaps the more urgent question for students and teachers alike is: *Will our education give us the courage to keep it alive?*

Fire and ice, competitions, and the balance of education

In our schools, we often see these forces at play. *Fire* is the rush to top exams, to win Olympiads, debates, MUN awards, or hackathons. *Ice* is the silent exclusion of those who cannot compete – the cold comparisons, the apathy towards anyone left behind.

But must education be only about feeding fire?

Competition versus excellence

A key distinction is often overlooked: competition is about beating others; excellence is about surpassing yourself.

- Competition can ignite fire, but it can also lead to stress, comparison, and ego-driven pursuits.
- Excellence, on the other hand, channels ambition into growth, curiosity, and skill-building – even if there is no trophy.
- Schools can guide students to focus on excellence, turning competitions into exercises in self-improvement, collaboration, and meaningful contribution, rather than mere prestige.

When guided well, these events train students not for prestige, but for participation in healing the world. The mathematics they learn may one day model climate solutions. The negotiation skills honed in MUNs may help prevent wars. The empathy practised in debates may cool the ice of hatred. The curiosity nurtured in Olympiads may ignite discoveries that serve humanity, not greed.

So, must competitions end in fire or ice? Not necessarily. The same events that sometimes fuel ego and prestige can also become platforms of healing – if reimagined with balance.

The question, *"What are we being educated for?"* does not ask us to abandon competitions altogether. It asks us to rebalance them – to ensure fire does not become greed, ice does not become hatred, and that every skill, every lesson, and every victory becomes a step towards making this world more just, more peaceful, and more alive.

Frost reminds us that the world could end in fire or in ice. Education, if held in balance, gives us another possibility: a world sustained by knowledge, warmed by compassion, and made better by the hands and hearts of those who learned not just to win, but to heal.

> *"Not the trophy, not the race,*
> *But the kindness in the pace.*
> *Win or lose, the measure true,*
> *Is how we cared in all we do."* – A student

Tagore and Gandhi: harmony over rivalry

Rabindranath Tagore rejected rigid competition, seeing education as a process of self-expression in harmony with nature. *"The highest education is that which does not merely give us information but makes our life in harmony with all existence."*

Similarly, Gandhi's *Nai Talim* emphasized learning through craft, self-reliance, and community service. He warned against ranking that divided children. *"By education, I mean an all-round drawing out of the best in the child and man – body, mind, and spirit."*

From their perspective, Olympiads and MUNs risk privileging intellect and external validation over creativity, service, and self-realization.

Steiner and Montessori: Freedom and creativity

Rudolf Steiner's Waldorf philosophy prioritizes imagination, art, and rhythm in learning. Competition, he argued, undermines individuality.

Maria Montessori also placed the child's inner development at the center: *"Free the child's potential, and you will transform him into the world."* Montessori classrooms emphasize mastery at one's own pace, not winning over others.

Competitions here might be reframed not as tests of rank but as collaborative exhibitions of skill.

Krishnamurti: The critique of comparison

J. Krishnamurti was radical in his rejection of competition. *"The moment you compare yourself with another, you destroy yourself."* Many Krishnamurti schools in India avoid competitions entirely.

A teacher in a Krishnamurti School explains:

> *"The moment you make learning about winning or losing, you introduce fear and comparison. We try to create a space where a child explores out of curiosity, not because a medal is at stake."* Ritu Srivasta, senior teacher at Rajghat Besant School.

Students here describe freedom rather than exclusion.

> *"At first I felt left out when my friends in other schools posted photos from MUNs. But then I realized I was exploring science fairs and theatre without worrying about judges. It feels freer,"* says a class 9 student at Rajghat.

Rethinking competitions

Competitions are not inherently good or bad – they mirror the educational philosophy behind them. In some contexts, they cultivate confidence, exposure, and teamwork. In others, they reproduce inequality, stress, and prestige culture.

If schools want competitions to be genuinely enriching, they must shift the emphasis from **winning to learning, from prestige to participation, from individual rivalry to collective growth**.

Perhaps the last word belongs to Tagore, who insisted that true education aligns our lives "in harmony with all existence." Competitions, when seen as shared journeys of discovery rather than trophies of pride, can move closer to that vision.

Example from Krishnamurti Schools / Rajghat Besant:

- Instead of a debate "tournament," students hold **dialogue circles** on global issues. They **research, present, and listen**, then collaboratively draft a "community resolution" like in MUN.
- For science or coding, instead of a hackathon prize, students **work together on projects** to solve real environmental problems and then **share the results with the local community or their parents.**

- In a **Model United Nations**, students don't just perform speeches; they learn the art of negotiation, of listening to perspectives beyond their own, of empathizing with nations in crisis.
- In a **debate**, beyond winning points, students can practice respectful disagreement and the courage to stand for truth.
- In an **Olympiad**, what matters is not just solving problems faster than others, but learning perseverance, collaboration, and joy in discovery.
- In a **hackathon**, teamwork, creativity, and innovation matter far more than any prize – because the real world will need these to solve climate emergencies, refugee crises, and disasters.

Rethinking competitions: a teacher's guide
If you're organizing a debate / hackathon / Olympiad – try this instead:

Focus on learning, not winning
- Celebrate **effort, improvement, and creativity**, not only the final scores.
- Add awards like: *"Best Collaboration," "Most Empathetic Argument," or "Most Innovative Idea."*
- Include **short reflection circles**: students share what they learned about teamwork, problem-solving, or themselves.

Make events collaborative and inclusive
- **Rotate roles** so every student tries speaking, moderating, or note-taking.
- Encourage **team-based projects** that address real-world problems.
- Host **school-wide festivals**, where all forms of expression – science, tech, art, and storytelling – get equal space.

Connect recognition to purpose
- Reward **community impact** and meaningful contributions, not just give medals.
- Encourage **mentorship**: past participants guide newcomers.
- Involve students in **co-designing rules and judging criteria**, giving them ownership and voice.

Shift the spotlight from podiums to processes – keep the excitement alive, but root it in inclusion, growth, and community impact.

Educating for the future: NEP, AI, and ethics

As we look ahead, the National Education Policy (NEP 2020) reminds us that education must be holistic, multidisciplinary, and rooted in social, emotional, and ethical learning. In a world increasingly shaped by Artificial Intelligence, automation, and rapid technological change, knowledge alone is not enough. Students must also develop empathy, ethical reasoning, collaboration, and creativity – skills that no AI can replace.

Competitions, projects, and classroom experiences should not merely reward speed or accuracy, but encourage curiosity, moral courage, and imagination. A student coding an AI model for climate solutions should also reflect on its social impact. A debate on global policy should teach negotiation *and* empathy. In this vision, education becomes a laboratory for developing human values alongside technical skills, preparing students not just to thrive in the future, but to shape it responsibly.

As Dr. Jane Goodall reminds us:

> *"What you do makes a difference, and you have to decide what kind of difference you want to make."*

Let our schools, our classrooms, and our competitions nurture not just winners, but thoughtful, compassionate, and creative citizens – the generation that will heal the world rather than compete to conquer it.

Kalpana Sharma is an educator with over 25 years of experience in teaching and school leadership. Born in Shimla, Himachal Pradesh, she has worked with a variety of schools, colleges, and educational organizations. She served as Principal at BSN Shimla before joining Rajghat Besant School, a Krishnamurti institution, a decade ago. Over the years, she has held multiple roles including Coordinator, Headmistress, and is now Head of Social-Emotional Wellbeing and Inclusive Education at Rajghat Besant School. Kalpana has a deep passion for inclusive education and has actively worked with schools across India to foster this spirit. She leads Project Naman, (https://keekli.in/dav-totu-organised-a-workshop-on-inclusive-education/ and https://keekli.in/education-beyond-books-loreto-students-explore-the-true-purpose-of-learning/) through which she has conducted free workshops on inclusive education, social-emotional learning, and ethical wellbeing for students, parents, and teachers in 15 schools in Himachal. She continues to teach English and work closely with students with special needs, inspiring both learners and educators with her commitment to holistic, value-driven education. She can be reached at <kalpana.sharma@rajghatbesantschool.org>.

Social contract in education

Neerja Singh

As we move towards 2030, we must prepare ourselves to answer new questions. What will be the nature and state of the world our students will live in? Are we readying them for the jobs and skills they will need not just to survive but to thrive in that new world? Do we understand the degree of the knowledge gap that a forward-looking education system will be expected to bridge? How can students and educators work towards such a future?

When the pandemic upstaged us by proving our fragility, it also framed our essential connectedness. The looming threat forced us to reimagine our future with collaboration at its centre. And the push came from UNESCO's report titled 'Reimaging our futures together: a new social contract for Education'. The report proposed that education could be viewed as a social contract in which there is an implicit agreement among members of a community, particularly educators and their students. It was argued that given the power of education to bring about profound change, a new social contract for education could repair past injustices while transforming the future.

This new social contract presented education as a public endeavour and a common good. However, the visions, principles, and proposals were put forth only as a starting point of a vital conversation. Born of a global consultation involving more than one million people, the new social contract for education was envisaged to help build a peaceful, just, and sustainable future for all.

COVID-19 had fundamentally and undoubtedly changed our educational experiences and notions of leadership. The new social contract in education tweaked the relationship between teachers, students, and knowledge, for instance. And one of the most succinct definitions of this new educator-student role came from Professor Yong Zhao of the School of Education at the University of Kansas and Dr Jim Watterston of the Melbourne Graduate School of Education in Australia. They said:

"Teachers no longer need to serve as the instructor, the sole commander of information to teach the students content and skills. Instead, the teacher serves other more important roles such as organizer of learning, curator of learning resources, counselor to students, community organizer, motivator and project managers of students' learning."

Zhao and Watterston also argued:
"It is incumbent upon all educators to use this crisis-driven opportunity to push for significant shifts in almost every aspect of Education: what, how, where, who, and when. In other words, Education, from curriculum to pedagogy, from teacher to learner, from learning to assessment, and from location to time, can and should radically transform."

UNESCO's report clearly and firmly placed educators at the centre of education, but what about the roles and responsibilities of the student in the social contract? Would 'student-centered learning' continue to be a passive concept, or would a student's functional role be redefined? How could an educator lead an educational change that encouraged and supported students in playing a proactive role in learning? Did we even need the traditional classroom?

Adventurous, captivating, and flexible. These three words describe what education is expected to be in the future. A paper co-authored by Zhao and Watterston identifies three major changes that should happen in education in the era of machine learning and AI integration.

The first emphasizes that content should highlight creativity, critical thinking, and entrepreneurship, rather than gathering and hoarding information. Humans cannot thrive by competing with machines; they need to be more human instead.

The second advocates greater control over their learning for the students. The teacher's role will then shift from instructor to curator of learning resources, counsellor, and motivator. This is the spot where

"active learning" will kick in, with a growing body of research suggesting that comprehension and memory are better when students learn in a hands-on way – through discussion and interactive technologies.

The third proposal insists that learning should change – "from the classroom to the world". With digital tools, it is no longer necessary for students to learn at the same time as each other. Imagine blended learning or a mix of online and face-to-face learning, also called the flipped classroom, where students read or watch lectures in their own time and solve problems in the presence of their teacher and peers.

The time has come perhaps for the decoupling of learning time and school time. And those involved are adjusting as students speed up their lectures, or lecturers begin dividing their presentations into five and ten-minute video segments. This could be the start of the end of the 45-minute period or the 50-minute lecture.

Image generated using AI.

But what about those who don't have the luxury of digital tools yet? The digital divide is not a new problem nor has it put a brake on change, "because the digital world moves faster in providing access than the physical one".

As a matter of fact, the only way United Nations' Sustainable Development Goal 4, which seeks to provide quality education for all by 2030, will be realized is if teachers in disadvantaged areas receive tools and materials digitally – perhaps via massive open online courses – and then pass them on to their students in the traditional way.

So, even if the digital divide won't hold back the coming revolution, it seems unlikely that the classroom will ever look the same again.

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Reimagining classrooms through archives

A teacher's reflection on the NCBS summer fellowship

Vaishnavi Bhat

When I first walked into the Archives as part of the NCBS Archives Public Fellowship*, I felt both curious and overwhelmed. It was like stepping into a vast ocean of information – files, exhibits, letters, lesson plans, and notes from another time. Getting lost in the sheer volume of archival material was, in itself, an experience. There was so much to read, so much to learn, and so much to make sense of. As a teacher, I found myself constantly asking: *What here can speak to children? What here can act as a pedagogical tool? What stories from this sea of information can help them better understand education in India, especially through the lens of policy, change, and lived experience?*

*A three-week in-person fellowship at the Archives at NCBS, Bengaluru. It is aimed at middle and high school teachers. The focus is on using archival records (old documents, letters, photos, scientific history material) as tools for teaching.

At first, it was difficult to find something that felt relevant for classroom use. But this challenge also opened up new ways of thinking. I realized I wasn't just being given documents, I was being given *questions*, and I was learning how to find the *right* ones. Slowly, I began to understand what it means to be a researcher: to stand before a mountain of knowledge, to frame a question from it, to pursue it relentlessly, to design your own method of inquiry, to test what you discover, and eventually, to piece it together into something coherent, meaningful, and shareable.

Photo courtesy: Vaishnavi Bhat

Vaishnavi Bhat presenting her project on the final day of the fellowship.

This insight into how researchers think and work is, I believe, what I will carry back most strongly from this fellowship. It has made me question how we approach information as teachers. We are often looking for answers. But this space taught me to get comfortable with uncertainty and look for questions instead.

The Archives revealed a layered and nuanced history of education in India through policies, textbooks, and the voices of those who shaped and challenged them. One of the most striking aspects of this journey was studying school textbook archives and seeing how they have evolved over time. These documents, simple as they may seem, are a reflection of our educational values, political shifts, and collective imagination. Understanding how a textbook is written and how it influences what and how we teach gave me an entirely new perspective on curriculum and its potential.

Along the way, I also found myself reflecting on the role of language in expressing thought. There were so many moments when I felt deeply moved, or thoughtful, or provoked by what I was reading, but I didn't always have the vocabulary to express it. I realized how important it is to build a language for reflection, for critique, for curiosity. This experience has made me want to strengthen my academic and expressive vocabulary, not just to communicate better, but also to think more effectively.

Despite being physically exhausted at times (the days were long, packed, and intense), my mind felt alive in ways it hadn't in a while. There's something incredibly energizing about thinking deeply, about encountering new ideas, about puzzling over how to connect the dots. I felt a creative shift inside me from under-confidence and hesitation to a quiet confidence that comes from trying, failing, learning, and trying again. Journaling regularly helped me track this shift. Even though I often laughed at myself for forgetting how to spell the simplest of words on tired days, I found comfort in writing things down.

Nearing the end of the fellowship, I felt both a sense of sadness and fulfillment. It's always bittersweet to come to the close of something transformative. But there was also a deep sense of pride in looking back and saying, *"Look how far we've come."* The process of crafting our teaching ideas, presenting them, and waiting for feedback gave us a taste of accomplishment. It felt real and rooted in our own journeys.

One of the most enriching parts of the fellowship was the teachers I had the privilege of working alongside. Their stories, questions, and laughter added layers to my own reflections. We were all walking parallel but different paths, and the learning that came from these shared experiences was invaluable. I also want to thank the people at the Archives for their warmth, generosity, and kindness. They made the space inviting, collaborative, and full of possibility.

This fellowship has reminded me that education is not just about classroom instruction, it's about context, history, questioning, and creativity. It's about stepping away from the whiteboard to explore new tools, new spaces, and new questions. For any teacher looking to breathe fresh life into their practice, think deeply about their role, and rediscover the joy of learning, this is an incredible opportunity.

To experiment, to wonder, to feel overwhelmed, to try again, to reflect, and to grow, that is what this journey has been. I am leaving with more questions than I arrived with, and that, I believe, is a sign of meaningful learning.

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A first step towards healing

Radhika Chhaparia

At the heart of the book *Where Does It Hurt?* lies the inevitability of hurt as part of human experience and the significance of those who help alleviate it.

Sometimes, as this book conveys both emphatically and poetically, the journey towards healing begins with a conversation about hurt itself, set in motion by asking a simple yet potent question: Where does it hurt?

Penned in verse by Samina Mishra and illustrated by Allen Shaw, *Where Does It Hurt?* is a thought-provoking book which explores the challenging subject of hurt, pain, and related emotions experienced by children as they go through life. Part of the Hook Book series[1], it certainly lives up to its promise of offering something short and engaging for young readers, yet interesting enough for the older ones.

Written in the form of a conversation between child protagonists and adult characters, the text is primarily a series of episodes rather than a single story. Each episode presents readers with a situation in which a child is found struggling with a challenging experience and ensuing emotions. The entire narrative is constructed thoughtfully as it charts a progression in two aspects. First, the likelihood of children's familiarity with the illustrated situations. Second, the complexity of emotions evoked through the experiences portrayed. In the first few pages, we encounter a little boy in physical pain after an accidental fall from his bicycle. Predictably, it leads to bruising, bleeding, and the loss of a tooth, whereas, in a later episode, a girl is found grappling with more complex emotions triggered by the loss of a loved one, which many readers would not have experienced yet and may find hard to empathize with. Each child character, no matter the circumstance, meets someone who pops the thoughtful question, "Where does it hurt?" kick-starting their journey towards healing. The text stays authentic to real-life experiences of unfortunate and emotionally challenging events and subtly conveys that sometimes our feelings don't disappear quickly or perhaps even completely. This aspect is conveyed through a sense of uncertainty which creeps into the narrative as it progresses towards more challenging life circumstances. After all, the immediacy and certainty with which a particular hurt can be assuaged not only depends on the help one receives but also on how deep it hurts in the first place.

Image courtesy: Penguin Random House India (https://www.penguin.co.in/)

Where Does It Hurt?
Samina Mishra (writer), Allen Shaw (illustrator)
Published by Duckbill, Sep. 2024, 40 pp.
Price: Rs.225/-

(1) Hook Book series, published by Duckbill (an imprint of Penguin Random House India) and designed by Priya Kuriyan, consists of chapter books in English for young readers. They primarily attempt to hook readers to stories which are fun, well-illustrated and short but also have an interesting story to tell, even for an older reader. Books in this series come with a short exercise or two to deepen a reader's engagement.

Sometimes, the length of time that has passed before one finally meets a caring soul can also impact our healing journey. Another contributing factor would be our own resilience. Finally, the closing lines in the book nudge all readers to recall a similar episode from their lives and inquire about what particularly occurred for them when they found themselves on either side of the question 'where does it hurt?' Did they feel relieved and cared for? Did they hesitate in asking another person about the reason behind their pain? Was it easy to talk about their feelings when someone reached out to them? Or did the question cause them to go even further inside their cocoon? Despite the seriousness of the topic, the overall tone of the book remains uplifting and the accompanying images in the book add towards this. Given that the book is aimed at young readers, it is befitting that each episode is resolved on a hopeful note and all characters in the story receive help from someone. In my view, multiple short plotlines, diverse settings and the variety of characters employed in the book will also help young readers relate to and grasp the familiar yet wide-ranging experience of hurt. The episodic format is also likely to naturally excite young readers to share similar anecdotes from their lives.

Generally, the articulation of a hurtful experience is difficult for most of us, but it can be particularly challenging for children. On the one hand, children could find their feelings overwhelming and consequently struggle with articulation. On the other, they could find themselves in the company of adults preoccupied with overcoming life circumstances such as chronic poverty, unemployment, violence, etc., causing them to deliberately hold back from communicating with adults. Understandably, children's helplessness in talking about their pain is often expressed in non-verbal ways such as tears, withdrawal from others, sadness, irritability, and tantrums. Their struggle to articulate difficult experiences is well-portrayed in Allen Shaw's illustrations and in the recurrence of the question 'Where does it hurt?' Not only does his artwork help us visualize what is expressed in words, it also personifies hurt and does so with a touch of humour. Along with other human characters there is also the quintessential villain *Hurt*, unmissable in its red suit and devilish horns. *Hurt* was a real surprise for me when I first read the book.

Brimming with emotions akin to other characters in the story, *Hurt* is seen afflicting one child after another in its indefatigable quest to cause pain, and is eventually driven away from various scenes of crime by those who care. What is outstanding about the images is that, much like the words, they too give rise to further thoughts and questions: Do I identify with the character *Hurt*? Who is responsible for my feelings? Could I blame someone for my hurt? How do I feel once I recognize that I hurt someone? Did I find any pleasure in it? Did I hurt someone unintentionally, and if not, what motivated me? Do I have the courage to ask someone I hurt, 'Where does it hurt?' or do I find it easier to silently walk away?

Illustration by Allen Shaw. Published with permission from Penguin Random House India.

Further questions that may arise in the minds of mature readers are: Was I hurt intentionally, or is my pain caused by unintended consequences, or a mere accident? Does the aforementioned consideration alter the way I now experience the event?

In my opinion, this short and well-illustrated book is remarkable in its ability to offer a sophisticated and easy to understand exploration of difficult life experiences and complex human emotions to readers as young as five. A mix of settings and the vibrant character *Hurt* make the book somewhat light-hearted even though its theme could easily weigh down any reader and I will encourage teachers to approach the book in a similar spirit when reading it with children.

In terms of accessibility of language and presentation of ideas, the book seems suitable for independent reading, group-reading, and a read-aloud with children of ages five and above. However, given the complexity of the theme, my recommendation would be to read it in a group-setting along with an adult when sharing the book with children below the age of 10. The two short exercises included at the end of the book seem appropriate for its youngest readers: each provides a space for personal reflection in the context of their own experience of hurt and pain. Teachers are encouraged to come up with similar exercises for older children. An art-based activity in which children are encouraged to express similar anecdotes through drawings could also be undertaken.

With senior-school children, the book appears to carry the potential of being a playful conversation starter to explore the significance of creating communities of care in their particular socio-cultural context, and discuss their notions of care and wellbeing. Hopefully, teachers will not shy away from taking this book to older children. For parents, this book serves as an important, accessible, and affordable guide on the topic. The universality of the theme would likely make it possible to facilitate book discussions with groups of diverse individuals and perhaps even intergenerational dialogues on the topic. Like the tip of an iceberg, *Where Does It Hurt?* points to further questions to reflect on for all readers irrespective of their age: Are certain painful situations avoidable, like war, bombing and displacement of communities? What holds me back from asking 'where does it hurt?' even when I'm aware of another's pain? Do I avoid interacting with those who appear to be gripped by sadness and loneliness?, and many more. Adult readers could also consider listening to the 'On Being' podcast with Ruby Sales[2] hosted by Krista Trippett, from which this book draws its inspiration.

As a final thought, I think an illustration or two of a role reversal wherein a child poses the question 'where does it hurt?' to an adult would've added another interesting layer to the book. Similarly, a child posing the question to another child. Nevertheless, nothing stops a keen reader of this book and of life to explore such aspects of human relationships during a book discussion.

(2) Ruby Nell Sales is an African-American social justice activist, scholar, and public theologian.

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Getting

This month, I wish to share my own reflection on the question:
"How can a teacher keep getting better at her work?"

And the emphasis is on the phrase *"keep getting"*.

Yes, an occasional course or a workshop often injects us with new zeal, ideas, or even fresh content, and fuels our engines – for a while. But what then? How does one *continue* to cruise along with *constant alertness to one's own learning needs?*

I stumbled upon a Ted talk which asked exactly this question.

One day, Dr Atul Gawande (a Boston-based American surgeon) realized that after a slow improvement in his medical practice for some years, he had plateaued. He wondered: Was there any way in which his practice could *continue to improve?* Those five years of medical school: were they sufficient to ensure that a doctor *improved continuously* for the rest of their career?

Of course not! Reflecting thus, he began to take a look at other professions. Sportsmen – even the very best – ALWAYS had a coach. Or did they? He discovered that coaching didn't start until 1875 – when Yale hired a coach. In all Yale-Harvard football matches for the next three decades, Yale consistently won each and every match – except three! The result? Harvard hired a coach!

Was coaching restricted to sports, then, he wondered?

The violinist Itzhak Perelman declared that he definitely had a coach: his wife! She had studied music with him, and then chosen to give up her profession (as a violinist) in order to support her husband. She did this by watching each of his performances and giving him constructive feedback thereafter.

Could he, Dr Gawande, get a coach? He approached his former professor, now retired, with that request. Prof. Bob Osteen agreed. So in Dr Gawande's next surgery, Bob Osteen was also present in the OT, quietly taking notes. After a very smooth surgery, Dr Gawande wasn't expecting any earth-shattering feedback. But Bob shared "little things" like:

- The light had swung out of the wound during the case.
- Your elbow goes up in the air once in a while, instead of resting comfortably.

better at what we do

Neeraja Raghavan

"Little things"? Definitely not! Especially for something as critical as surgery!

Clearly, his coach was of enormous help in:

- Drawing his attention to "little things".
- Becoming his external eyes and ears.
- Breaking down the fundamentals.
- Providing a more accurate picture of HIS reality.
- Coming up with a checklist.

This reinforced Dr G's resolve to *keep getting coached* – and that set his learning curve on the rise again.

I now asked: If a doctor finds five years of medical school insufficient to ensure continuous improvement, how can a one-or-two-year B Ed for teachers ensure that their practice keeps getting better?

Was there a *consistent coaching practice for teachers* anywhere in the world?

My search led me to the age-old practice of Lesson Study in Japan. In this very interesting video of a grade II math teacher, Lesson Study is shown as consisting of these steps:

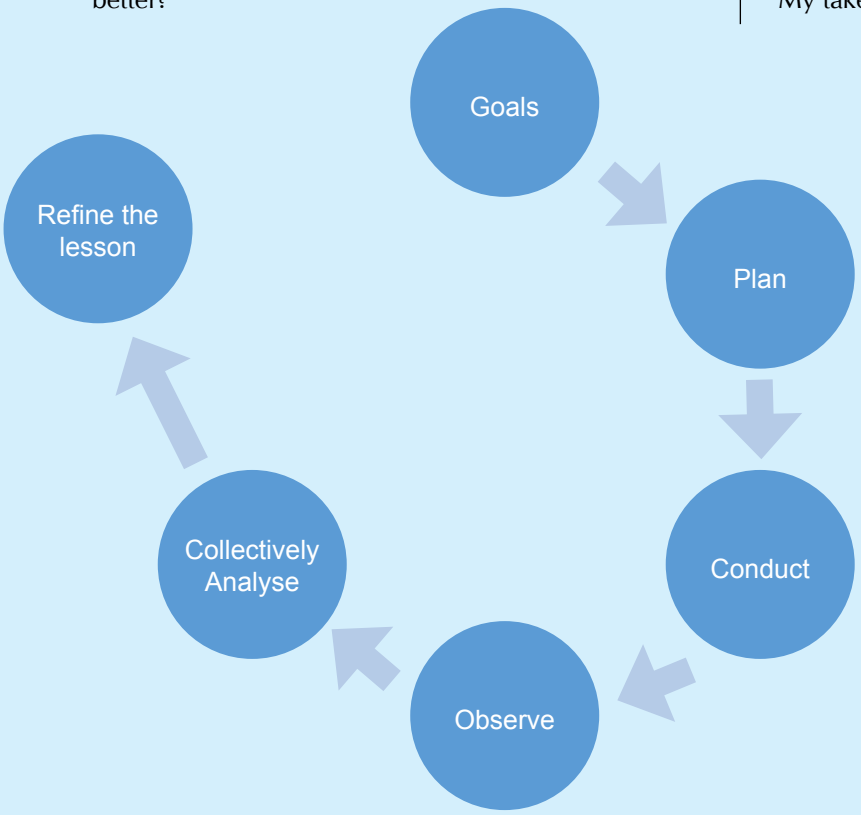
1. The grade II math teacher sat with a group of colleagues and planned his lesson.
2. Then, he transacted it – with his colleagues observing the class and taking notes.
3. All of them then collectively analyzed the lesson.
4. He incorporated their feedback and refined this lesson for future transactions.

Do watch this clip, as it will help you gain a better understanding.

My takeaways are:

- Teachers who wish to continuously improve can do so through the process of Lesson Study.
- For this, they need to find trusted educators who will observe their classroom transactions and offer constructive feedback.

And the cherry on the cake? A community of practice slowly builds!
Any takers?



Flow of steps for Lesson Study

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The illusion of grandeur

Prioritizing infrastructure over teachers

Prachi Lahiri

As I was driving down the road, my eyes fell on a huge hoarding by the side of a busy road in Bengaluru. It was an advertisement for a school. It proudly presented an Olympic size swimming pool, a gym, sprawling acres of land, digital boards, and lush green playgrounds. There was no mention of the teachers. It was completely silent about the teachers' qualifications, their experiences, and their achievements. There was no mention of the teacher-student ratio either. The advertisement could easily be mistaken for that of an apartment complex or resort.

In the race to attract admissions and emerge as "top" educational institutions, many schools in India have begun to prioritize infrastructure and aesthetics over the very heart of education – the quality of teaching. While these features create an impressive façade for parents who seek the best for their children, they often mask the underlying deficiencies in the core of educational quality – most notably, the lack of focus on teacher training, experience of the teachers, their achievements, and effective student-teacher engagement.

Education in India is becoming increasingly commodified. Private schools mostly operate like businesses, where parents are the customers and students, the products. Schools invest heavily in infrastructure to lure the 'customers'. Acres of land, air-conditioned auditoriums, and branded school buses with GPS trackers have become the norm. The emphasis is on selling a status symbol rather than providing a strong academic foundation. For example, rather than promoting the importance of simple and healthy home-cooked meals, these advertisements glorify a cafeteria with a global cuisine.

Image generated using AI.

Such advertisements distract young parents from what truly matters. There is little discussion about the values and vision that the institution follows, or the qualifications and training of the faculty members, or the teaching methodologies employed by the institution. The message is clear: parents are expected to be wowed by the outer shell and not probe into the academic core.

Though there is a constant need for all other professionals to upgrade their skills, a bachelor's in education done decades ago is well accepted for a schoolteacher. The training programmes made available by the government are neither interactive, nor engaging, nor beneficial to the teacher in her classroom.

The recruitment and training of teachers in many Indian schools lacks standardization and rigor. Often, they are expected to teach across multiple subjects or grade levels. Many private schools, especially the budget ones, hire fresh graduates with little to no training, because they are affordable. There's little investment in continuous professional development or exposure to new teaching techniques. As a result, teaching becomes more about rote learning and syllabus completion rather than nurturing critical thinking or creativity.

When was the last time a school proudly advertised the qualifications or accomplishments of its teachers on a billboard or brochure? The experience of a teacher who has produced national toppers or whose students have achieved exceptional success in co-curricular activities is never celebrated. School billboards often showcase the names and photos of students who score above 90 percent, creating a skewed image of student performance. By highlighting only the highest achievers, schools present a selective narrative that promotes academic excellence while ignoring the broader spectrum of student efforts and progress. This practice subtly pushes under the carpet those students who might not have achieved high marks but have shown improvement, creativity, or strength in non-academic areas. As a result, it fosters a culture of comparison and pressure, while marginalizing the achievements and needs of the majority who fall outside the narrow definition of "success."

In a student's life, where a teacher's attention and appreciation are the key factors for development, the silent crisis of the same is often overlooked. The student-teacher ratio is overwhelming and burdensome on teachers. With high numbers, assessing each student's learning pace, offering individual feedback, or addressing emotional and psychological needs becomes an impossible task. Despite this, schools continue to project a false image of personalized education through marketing tactics. The reality on the ground is starkly different. Overcrowded classrooms, overburdened teachers, and one-size-fits-all teaching methodologies dominate the scene. This severely impacts student learning outcomes and their overall development.

Parents, in their pursuit of providing the "best" for their children, are also caught in this infrastructure-driven race, often without asking deeper questions. How experienced are the teachers? What are their teaching styles? What professional development do they receive? How does the school measure learning outcomes? These questions are frequently sidelined in favour of the more tangible and flashy criteria. This consumerist mindset pushes schools to invest more in cosmetic upgrades than academic quality.

It is high time that Indian schools and parents realigned their priorities. While infrastructure is undoubtedly important – especially for providing a safe and engaging environment – it cannot replace the fundamental role of a qualified and passionate teacher. Schools must invest in building robust teacher development programs, offer sustainable salaries, and create a culture where teachers are respected and empowered. Moreover, there is a pressing need for a cultural shift that places teachers at the centre of the educational discourse. Celebrating teacher achievements, involving them in curriculum decisions, and offering them platforms for sharing best practices can go a long way in improving the overall quality of education. As India aspires to become a global leader in education, it must look beyond the surface and invest in the people who matter most – the teachers.

Prachi Lahiri is a teacher with more than a decade's experience. She is a member of the Curricular Area Group on Social Science by the National Syllabus and Teaching-Learning Material Committee. Prachi's research paper, titled "The Trials and Triumphs of the Indian Schoolteachers during the COVID-19 Pandemic," was accepted by UNESCO under the Education for Resilience initiative, a platform of UNESCO's International Institute for Educational Planning (IIEP). Another research paper by her titled *"Impact and Influence of Teachers on the Lives of Migrant Children"* was published in the *Journal of Culture and Values in Education* (JCVE), a peer-reviewed, open-access academic e-journal dedicated to cultural and educational research. She can be reached at <lprachi@npshsr.com>.

Sexuality education in schools in India

A case study and lesson plan for teachers

Ketaki Chowkhani

Gender and sexuality are some of the taboo topics within school education. They get relegated to gender sensitization programs and if possible, sex education programs, which are often conducted by external resource persons. In this article and the lesson plan that follows, I will explain some of the current debates around sexuality education that teachers and schools face vis a vis adolescents. This will draw from my book *The Limits of Sexuality Education: Love, Sex, and Adolescent Masculinities in Urban India*, where I discuss how conceptualizing adolescent masculinities can help us rethink sexuality education in urban India. The lesson plan will help teachers integrate ideas of gender and sexuality within the curriculum in a seamless manner, without resorting to embarrassment.

In my research, that included talking to teachers and analyzing school curriculum, I maintain that sexuality education, the way it is taught in schools – either through external resource persons, such as NGOs, or sex educators – is often aimed at middle school students. In my book, there are two chapters that would be of specific interest to school teachers. I would like to discuss these so that teachers are aware of the latest scholarship and debates within sexuality education and can make informed decisions within the classroom and in their teaching practice.

The first idea that will be of interest to teachers is an examination of the curriculum on sexuality education produced by different stakeholders. These include the State, feminist organizations, Christian organizations, and the sexologists' community. Reviewing the curriculum produced by these different actors, I maintain that they form four discourses on sexuality education. My focus in reviewing the curriculum is to analyze how they understand questions of adolescent male desire, sexuality, pleasure, love, relationships, and romance. I arrive at the conclusion that:

> The feminist discourse brings to the fore the social and political context of sexuality education, stressing a Rights-based discourse; the Christian organization brings in an extensive discussion of romance and love; the State discourse brings in the scientific and the moral discourse; and the sexological discourse, while located within the scientific, crucially brings in a discussion of sexual pleasure. I examine each of these discourses in detail, suggesting that individually each represents only a partial approach to sexuality education. (Chowkhani, 2024, 4).

The curriculum, I maintain, is not only for the middle school, but is also an adult imagination of what sexuality education must be. Teachers must be aware that we often impose our adult ideas on young people, especially teenagers, and that sometimes listening to them will help us teach them better. This is precisely what I explore in the other chapters, which examine adolescent male sexual knowledge and romance to show how our adult conceptualization of adolescent sexuality is limited, which makes our curriculum on sexuality also limited.

I also note that what is missing within the curriculum and discussion on sexuality education is a healthy discussion of love and romance. Sexual pleasure is discussed in various ways in the different discourses on sexuality education: through masturbation, orgasms, and female pleasure. But I maintain that there is a missing discourse of love within the curriculum. The Christian discourse teaches about love and romance, but their imagination is limited to heterosexual love and/or love within the same caste/class/religion. A wider, healthier imagination of love and romance is necessary to be included in the curriculum. In the lesson plan that follows, I discuss in detail how to include discussions of love within the school curriculum.

The other chapter that might be of interest to teachers in school is the one titled *I am a teacher, I think the worst: teacher responsibilities and regulation of student romance in schools in Mumbai*. This chapter contains interviews with teachers from different schools in Mumbai to understand how they perceive and negotiate with student romances. The aim is to understand the teacher's position vis-a-vis students, the administration, and parents. Many of the teachers I interviewed were walking a tightrope, caught between students and school administrators who would hold them responsible should something happen to the students. The teachers were not averse to student romance, but they felt personally responsible should that spiral into a pregnancy or sexually transmitted diseases. As the title of the chapter suggests, they think the worst, making a direct leap from romance to pregnancy. In research on adolescent male romance, my interviews with young men suggested that they were very careful about having sexual intercourse with their girlfriends, and that some of them were genuinely happy just holding their girlfriends' hands. This suggests that a lot of fears the teachers have about adolescent romance are rather unfounded. I maintain that schools and teachers are more concerned about the reputation of the school rather than the safety and health of the student. They seek to regulate students' movements, clothes, and interactions based on an imagination of the depraved teenager, which I have already discussed does not hold true since adolescent boys are very thoughtful about sex, romance, and desire. Scandals in the school can lead to harsher punishments and restrictions on students. This leads to what Italian philosopher Giorgio Agamben calls a state of exception which is a permanent state of emergency in response to conflict. In the school setting, any scandal leads to a state of exception, where all students are governed by a sense of emergency at all times.

School teachers are especially alert to student romance during school trips, and have a tough time navigating this liminal space. The ones who are most comfortable with student romance and are able to deal with it with much grace and tact, are often school counsellors and psychologists. They play the role of the empathetic adult. My point here is that it is not easy being a teacher since one is caught between caring for students and caring for the reputation of the school.

Illustrations: Shilpy Lather

My contention is that as teachers we need to rethink the gap between adults and adolescents. If we can demand of adolescents to be responsible like adults, we must also be open to the fact that we were once adolescents ourselves, and that maybe our adolescent desires have still not left us. This reduces the generational gap between adults and adolescents. One needs to not only question adolescents for their behaviour, but adults too; the latter is often left scot-free when it comes to apportioning blame for adolescent errors. This, I maintain, will help in also rethinking sexuality education, since we, as adults will not think of adolescents as the 'other' but understand them as part of ourselves, a self which was also young not so long ago.

Lesson plan

There are two ways to indirectly include sexuality education within the school curriculum. The first is in the literature class and the second in the art class.

Literature class, especially English classes

Prescribe to the students various texts from classic and contemporary literature in English, ranging from British, American, and Indian writing in English, which deal with love and romance. Examples could be romantic dramas from Shakespeare, novels from Jane Austen, or contemporary fiction from Shashi Deshpande. The teachers can also include more classical texts in translation such as Kalidasa's poems *Kumarasambhavam* or *Meghadutam*, which have themes of love and longing. Teachers can also include readings from Ruth Vanita and Salim Kidwai's book *Same Sex Love in India*, and Sufi poetry from Rumi, which explore themes of different forms of love. These texts, which include a literary repertoire of drama, novels, poetry, short stories, will expose students to a rich variety of love: love for a lover, love for the country, same sex love, love for god, love within the family, and so on. Teachers can also use bell hooks' book *All About Love* as a guide to their teaching on love and romance, since love comes in all shapes, sizes, and forms. Teachers can also use audio-visual aids, especially cinema to discuss other forms of love, like love between siblings, or love between a parent and their child. Videos on consent can also be shown when discussing romance and love between two people.

Some of the class discussions and assignment can be around:

1. What is love?
2. How does one differentiate between different forms of love?
3. What does one do when one is 'in love'?
4. What is consent?
5. What do you feel when you are in love – how would you process these emotions?

Role play can be used in class to discuss different forms of love. Students can act out dramatic scenes from plays on love. Students should also be encouraged to understand what is acceptable in love – like care, affection, consent, respect, dignity, and what is not acceptable, like violence, force, coercion, jealousy. Role play can be used in these cases to understand love within a romantic relationship.

How is love connected to sexuality education? Relationships education, romance, and love, are an integral part of sexuality, and as I mentioned earlier, there is a missing discourse of love within the sexuality education curriculum. Love needn't be addressed solely through a different sexuality education curriculum, but can be included within the larger curriculum of literary studies.

Art classes

The other way to discuss sexuality education is to talk about the erotics of the body and this can be done very well in the art class.

Explain to the students the proportions of the male and female body. This will expose students to the external genitalia without any embarrassment to the teacher or the student. Ask the students to study the human body in the nude, in different poses. This will help the student understand the shape and form of the human body. The following assignment can be given

1. Draw the human body in the nude, in the following positions: standing, sitting, lying down.
2. Draw the female and male body in the nude in the standing position, indicating the various parts of the body, including the external genitalia.

While biology classes can cover the internal genitalia and the physiology of pregnancy, contraception, puberty, and so on, art classes can cover the erotics of sexuality, which scholars of sexuality education around the world point out is missing within the curriculum.

Another way art classes can be used to study the erotics of sexuality is to use clay modeling to sculpt the human body. This can be done after the drawing classes, so that the students have already learnt about the proportions of the human body and face and are able to reproduce it in 3D. Ask the students to make a bust of a human being, understanding the dynamics of the human face. Next, ask the students to sculpt the human body. The following assignments can be given.

1. Sculpt the human body in the nude – you can choose the male or female form.
2. Sculpt the human face.

Why is it important to learn to sculpt the human body in the nude? This is so that the students can learn about the body through touch, not just through words and written text. Through touch, they can understand the curves and shapes of different human bodies, how the torso is differently shaped from the arms and legs, where the muscles are positioned, how the rib cage is important, where the external genitalia lie, and how the skeletal and bone structure of the human body is. This is to address the erotics of sexuality education in a classroom without embarrassment to the teacher or student, since it is done for the sake of art and to understand the human body. A clinical approach can also be taken to this exercise to make it less uncomfortable to everyone involved.

As mentioned earlier, biology classes can also take a clinical approach to sexuality education by talking about the physiology of the reproductive systems. This way, sexuality education is distributed within various subjects without needing to be separately taught as a subject. This helps in integrating sexuality education within the larger school curriculum, without having the embarrassment of teaching it as a separate subject. This is to aid both the teachers and students to tackle the subject of sexuality, sex, love, and romance in a 'normal' fashion rather than make it a matter of pride or shame.

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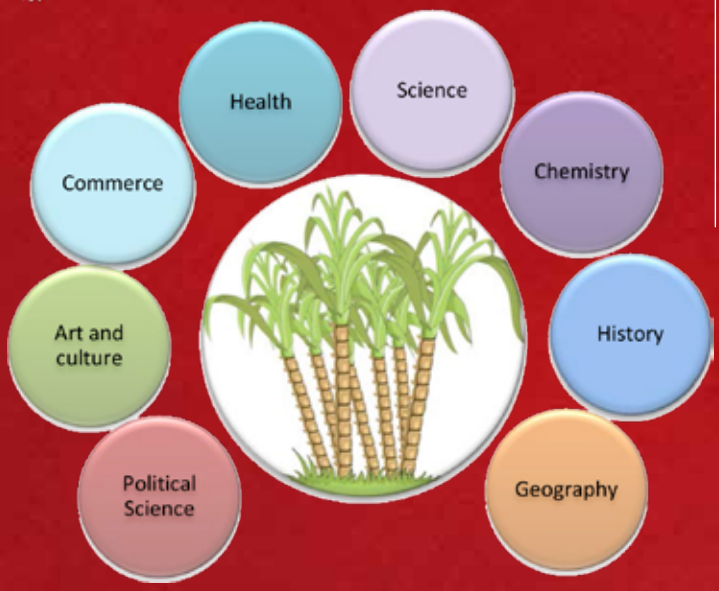
Hello, sweetness!

Sujata C

India has the dubious distinction of being the world capital for diabetes. To create awareness of the risks of high consumption of sugar among school children, the government has mandated the installation of a 'Sugar Board' in CBSE schools that displays the recommended intake of sugar and the amount of sugar in foods that children love.

This is an attempt to increase nutritional awareness among children and promote preventive healthcare. Hence, a project on sugar will further push children to learn everything about sugar – the one thing that is everyone's favourite and nobody's requirement. This project can be done with students of all classes and scaled to their level of understanding. It cuts across subjects.



So why do we love sugar so much? Science says that eating sugar releases endorphins, which are mood boosting hormones that create pleasurable sensations. The feel-good sensation makes you want to eat it more and more. But over-stimulation can lead to addictive behaviour, which sugar has a potential for. The brain's sensitivity to the feel-good hormones decreases with over exposure and the body needs higher doses of sugar to achieve the same effect. After eating sweets or sugar, the body experiences a sugar high which is very enjoyable and this is followed by a crash when the endorphin levels drop and the body experiences something similar to withdrawal symptoms that are characterized by irritability, mood swings, and cravings. While this can be explained to students of higher classes you will have to start with the basics for the younger children.

Sugar and health: Sugar is called white poison, because it provides empty calories, no nutrients and brings health risks. Since sugar can be addictive, over consumption leads to various health conditions such as obesity, diabetes, and tooth decay. Sugar also reduces immunity and invites a host of ailments by feeding the harmful bacteria. Packaged foods often contain sugar as it enhances taste. Tomato ketchup, yogurt, salad dressing, mayonnaise, all contain sugar. You will find the words 'added sugar' on the package – this is called hidden sugar and can come under different names such as fructose, maltose, dextrose, etc. Free sugar, on the other hand, is the white crystal sugar we add to milk, tea, coffee, sweets, *kheer*, cookies, cakes, etc.

Make a list of food items that contain hidden sugar.

Photo by Elena Leya on Unsplash

Talk: Ask your class to speak to someone in their family or extended circle who suffers from diabetes – Type 1 or 2.
WHO recommends that only 10% of the energy intake for both adults and children can come from free sugar. For additional health benefits, less than 5% is recommended. But doctors say it is advisable to consume as little sugar as possible and even eliminate it entirely if possible. A baby's diet from conception to two years (the first 1000 days of a child) must be sugarfree, doctors say and many baby food brands are complying with this rule. **How much sugar are you consuming every day? Calculate. Track it for three days – make a note in a diary.**

Compare: Make a table to compare the sugar content of coke vs homemade lassi and lemon juice.

Schools now must display a Sugar Board which looks like this:

Images generated using AI.

Language: Examine the roots of the word sugar. *Ikshu* is Sanskrit for sugarcane. Study the similarity between the words, sucre, saccharine, shakkar, and zuker.

Why is sugar called *chini* in Hindi? Find out.

Make a sentence using sweetness as a metaphor, and idioms such as sweet talk, sugar-coated, etc.

Write a poem/limerick/haiku on sugar.

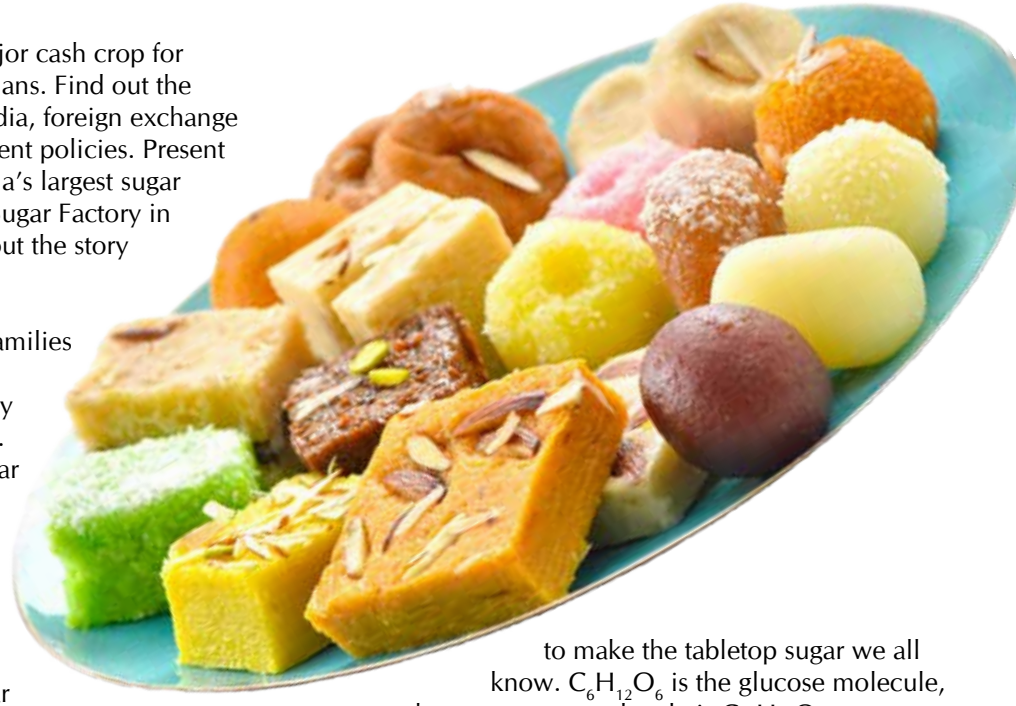
Botany: Where does sugar come from? Discuss the plant, a grass native to New Guinea islands in the Pacific Ocean, and how it thrives in hot and humid climates. *Sacchurumrobustum* is the wild species of sugarcane, which was domesticated and hybridized through agricultural techniques. How is the sugarcane different from other grasses? Make a chart to explain.

By Ton Rulkens – Flickr: sugar cane, CC BY-SA 2.0
https://commons.wikimedia.org/w/index.php?curid=15081463

Map work: Locate sugar producing nations on a map.

Geography: Brazil is the world's largest producer of sugarcane and India holds the second position. Roughly 80% of India's sugarcane is produced in three states: Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Karnataka. Older students can be asked to find out: How much sugarcane does India produce? How much land is under sugar cultivation – in the world and in India? Which state in India is the highest producer of sugarcane? Which is the sugarcane harvest season? Ask how many students have actually seen a sugarcane field.

Commerce: Sugarcane is a major cash crop for India, supporting crores of Indians. Find out the size of the sugar industry in India, foreign exchange earnings, and related government policies. Present this information on a chart. Asia's largest sugar factory used to be the Nizam Sugar Factory in Nizamabad, Telengana. Find out the story behind its rise and fall.



'Sugar barons' are influential families that own/control the sugar manufacturing businesses. They are often politically connected. Find out names of popular sugar barons of India.

The Government of India has recently passed an order approving the addition of 20% ethanol to petrol. Ethanol is a by-product of sugar production and is mixed with gasoline to reduce carbon emission. Find out how this will impact older vehicles and why ethanol is a cleaner burning alternative to fossil fuels.

Did You Know: Mauritius has a sugar museum to familiarize visitors with sugar, its production, history, culture, and economy since sugar is a major industry there. Does any other nation have a sugar museum? Find out.

Chemistry/Science: How is crystal sugar made? Familiarize the class with the process. Discuss the role of sulphur in refining sugar. Why is sulphur-free sugar popular among the health conscious? What harm does sulphur cause to the body?

Talk about the different types of sugarcane based products: misri, khand, jaggery, brown sugar, and white sugar.

Explain, with the help of videos, how sugar is made, starting with the process of harvesting, milling, etc. If possible arrange a visit to a sugar factory. Discuss how sugarcane juice is processed to make the tabletop sugar we all know. $C_6H_{12}O_6$ is the glucose molecule, whereas a sugar molecule is $C_{12}H_{22}O_{11}$ – glucose and fructose bonded together.

Find out how sugar is broken down in the body? What is the difference between natural sugars (in fruits/honey) and added sugars? Write a report. Why do we feel heavy after eating dessert? Find out.

Experiment: Test for sugar content in common drinks with Benedict's solution.

Cooking: Make sugar syrup – 1 string, 2 string, and 4 string consistency. Prepare caramel syrup.

Source: www.commons.wikimedia.org

Scientist Dr. Janaki Ammal is one lady every Indian must know about. She was a trailblazer, the first botanist of the nation, known for her research on sugarcane hybrids and brinjal. She is credited with hybridizing the sweetest variant of sugarcane (*Saccharum officianarum*) for Indian soil conditions. This eventually led to India becoming the world's second largest sugarcane producer in the world.

History: Ancient India was not only growing sugarcane as early as the Vedic period, but had also pioneered sugar extraction and crystallization techniques long before the rest of the world.

Photo: Elena Leya on Unsplash

Photo: Gaurav Kumar on Unsplash

This knowledge travelled westward via trade and conquest, forming the foundation of the global sugar industry. Archaeo-botanical findings of sugarcane phytoliths in ancient Indian sites support early cultivation. It spread to the rest of the world through human migration and trade.

Sugarcane finds mention in Atharva Veda and CharakSamhita, the foundational Ayurvedic textbook on traditional Indian medicine. The book describes sugarcane as a natural diuretic, sweet, and wholesome substance with cooling properties. It qualifies sugarcane juice obtained from chewing as superior. **Prepare a note on sugarcane in CharakSamhita.**

Greek historian Nearchus (4th century BCE), accompanying Alexander the Great to India, referred to sugarcane as, "A reed in India that brings forth honey without the help of bees." New Guinea and the Caribbean islands also grew sugar in the olden days.

The history of sugar is tainted with the sweat and tears of slavery. When people discovered how sugar enhances the taste of food, the demand for sugar surged unimaginably. To cater to this, sugarcane production was scaled up to massive levels. The need for farm hands was met through trans-Atlantic slave trade. People from Africa were brought to the Caribbean islands, where massive sugar plantations were grown. Slave based plantation economy thus came into being and with it the untold stories of the miserable lives of the slaves. With mechanization of agriculture, this dark chapter in the history of sugar was closed. Older students can prepare a note on **Sugarcane and Slavery – The Bitter Truth**.

Prepare a timeline of sugar through the ages.

Culinary arts: Who doesn't love freshly pressed sugarcane juice with a squeeze of lemon and a dash of ginger on a hot summer afternoon? Chewing on freshly cut sugarcane stalks and slurping up the sweet juice is a cherished childhood memory.

Traditionally, sugar candy dolls were given during various festivals like Sankranti and Diwali, both in North and South India.

Batasha is a traditional Indian aerated sugar candy, often used as prasad in temples and during festivals in North India. It is also consumed as a sweet treat and can be found in various shapes and colours. **Watch a video to see how *batasha* is made.**

Environment: The dry pithy residue that remains after the extraction of juice from sugarcane is called bagasse. Traditionally, majority of sugar factories reused the bagasse as biofuel to generate steam and electricity for their own operations. It continues to be a source of biofuel but in a limited way. Bagasse is also a green and eco-friendly substitute for plastic and is used to make packaging material, cutlery, cups, etc. Innovative uses have been devised for bagasse.

- In agriculture as organic matter to improve soil health.
- A low-cost medium for mushroom cultivation.
- Used as a base to make biodegradable, eco-friendly paper, cutlery, cups, plates, etc.

Sugar substitute: With diabetes becoming a global pandemic, many sugar substitutes have entered the market, among these are stevia, monk fruit, and xylitol.

- Stevia is a herb with sweet tasting leaves and can be grown in a pot.
- Monk fruit is native to South China and not easily accessible in India.
- Xylitol is a sugar alcohol present in most plant material. Humans and animals also produce trace quantities of xylitol while breaking down carbohydrates. It is extracted from plants and made available in crystals for use as an artificial sweetener.

Prepare a chart on sugar substitutes and their uses.

Spiritual lessons from sugarcane: Sugarcane is often used as a metaphor for something that may seem tough on the outside but contains hidden sweetness within. To enjoy its juice, the cane must be crushed – symbolizing the effort needed to extract value or meaning from something. Similarly, the wisdom in sacred scriptures cannot be truly appreciated until it is simplified and made accessible. A cold press is needed to extract juice from sugarcane, just as a *guru* is needed to extract and convey the essence of knowledge.

In this metaphor, sweetness refers to knowledge, and the *guru* is the one who helps us access and savour it. The soul naturally longs for this sweetness – the clarity, depth, and joy that true knowledge brings – and it is through the *guru's* guidance that the soul is able to experience it.

To conclude the project on a philosophical note, reflect on the concept of sweetness in thought, word and action – a principle that encourages us to express gentleness, kindness, and grace in everyday life, allowing the sweetness of inner wisdom to flow outwardly in all that we do.

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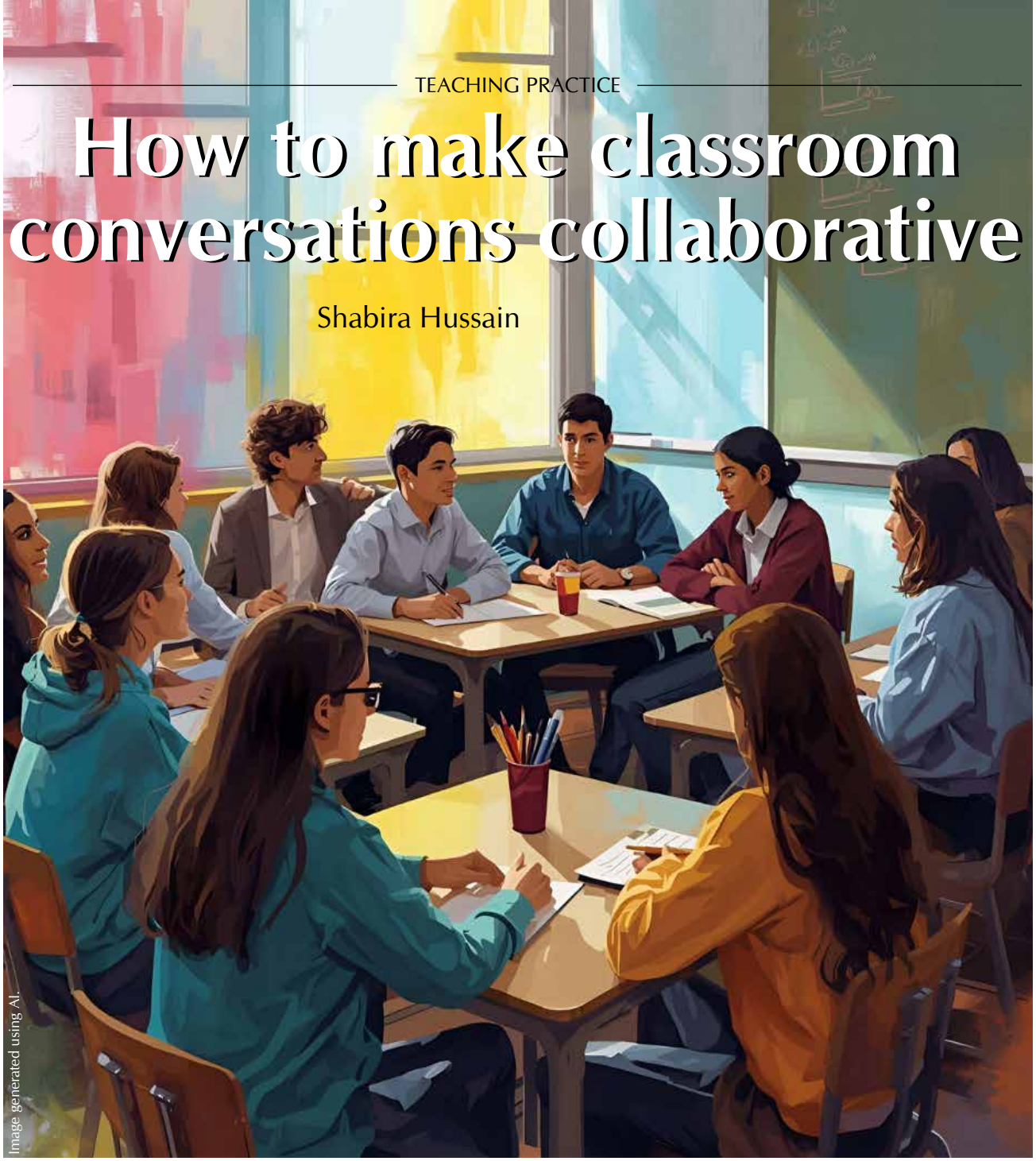
How to make classroom conversations collaborative

Shabira Hussain



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I once witnessed a literature teacher facing some heat from her students. They were protesting because their answers were marked wrong: "But why? Our explanation is different, but it still makes sense." A few more voices chimed in, not to explore the question, but to insist that their version had to be accepted. The teacher patiently replied, "You know 2 + 2 = 4, and that's correct. But 3 + 1 is also 4, and so is 5-1. There are multiple ways to arrive at the same result, but sometimes one way is clearer and better than the others."

Neither the students nor the teacher is wrong. Why then was there a disagreement?

This hit me during a recent circle time activity. Students were asked to brainstorm and present ways to survive on a deserted island without any external help. After the first group presented its strategies, the other groups started questioning and criticizing the strategies instead of exploring them further. Predictably, the group that was presenting got defensive. Within minutes, the discussion spiralled

into something far from its intent – a full-blown DEBATE!

Sounds familiar?

We witness such scenes in our classrooms all the time. Students often feel like they must prove themselves right and others wrong. And let's be honest – we teachers sometimes fall into this trap too.

But what if we flipped this? What if everyone is on the same side? What if we made space for conversations where multiple perspectives coexist without the need for a clear winner?

The island discussion could have been better managed by encouraging students to approach each other's ideas with curiosity rather than criticism, perhaps starting with questions like "What inspired this idea?" or "How could this work in different situations?"

As a debate coach, I spend plenty of time teaching students to build strong arguments and defend their viewpoints. But not *every* conversation needs to be a battle of wits. Sometimes, the real win is in understanding, not in winning.

Here are some practical strategies for teachers to transform debates into dialogues:

1. **Argument versus discussion:** We often crib that students never follow instructions – though they were instructed to discuss, they ended up debating! But, what if they don't know the difference? So, once in a while, have a conversation about it, or, better still, model both scenarios. With the help of other teachers or students, do a role play to show both scenarios and let the students realize the difference. This hands-on experience may lead to clarity.
2. **Set clear norms:** Before beginning an activity or discussion, state – even if you have done this in the previous class – that students need to respectfully listen first, then reflect, restate, and ask questions to seek clarity. The responder should also pause, restate the question, and respond only to what is asked without being defensive.
3. **Promote curiosity over criticism:** Students may sometimes dismiss others' answers as impossible or incorrect without considering the possibilities behind those ideas. When a student says, "That's impossible" or "That's not correct," gently redirect the conversation by encouraging them to ask exploratory questions like, "What inspired your thinking?" or "How could we improve this idea?" This shift from criticism to curiosity fosters collaborative thinking and ensures a supportive environment where every student feels comfortable sharing their thoughts, knowing their ideas will be valued and refined rather than rejected.
4. **Facilitate time to pause and reflect:** Giving students time to think and process ideas can increase their chances of considering or accepting different perspectives. Be open to the possibility that this reflection time may also lead to well-formed and stronger arguments. Encouraging thoughtful pauses supports deeper conversations and constructive dialogue. So, make a habit of giving students time to think whenever you hold discussions.
5. **Encourage active listening:** Effective conversations begin with active listening – a skill often lacking in students today. To foster this, create opportunities for them to become intentional listeners rather than impulsive speakers. A simple yet impactful practice is to have every student restate or summarize a peer's point before responding. This not only enhances comprehension but also cultivates empathy and respect for diverse perspectives.

By intentionally creating opportunities for dialogue, teachers can transform classroom discussions into meaningful learning experiences that build understanding, empathy, and collaborative thinking.

Shabira Hussain describes herself as a curious learner rather than a teacher. As the first girl from her village, Sikka (Jamnagar), to step out to study and work, she sees the world as her university, people as her professors, and each day as a new chapter. An amateur writer, she is the author of *My Green Self*, inspired by her love for planters and plants. She regularly shares her reflections on LinkedIn. She can be reached at <shabirahussain123@gmail.com>.

How do you write?

Deepak Manjraker

Writing is an art, yet many students see it merely as a tool for scoring marks. Literature is often taught with limited objectives, focusing on exam performance rather than skill development. Teaching methods overlook the broader applications of literature, such as contextual understanding, critical thinking, and communication skills. The "general-to-specific" writing technique offers a constructive solution, fostering clarity, coherence, and engagement. This article explores its significance, structure, and advantages while aligning with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, which emphasizes structured writing for critical thinking and academic success.

Literature review

Scholars emphasize the role of structured writing in improving comprehension. Smith (2020) states that the general-to-specific method enhances readability and prevents ambiguity. Jones (2019) highlights its effectiveness in expository writing, ensuring logical progression. Brown (2021) finds that students using this method perform better in assessments. NEP 2020 *(Paragraph 4-13, Section 4, School Education)* supports structured writing techniques for developing communication and critical thinking skills.

Research and scope

So how well are schools training their students to write? A research was undertaken as a qualitative

Photo: Sakti Prasanna Mohanty
Courtesy: DAV Public School, Pokhariput

classroom-based study aimed at exploring the pedagogical effectiveness of the general-to-specific writing technique in English Literature classrooms at the secondary and senior secondary levels. It involved analyzing student-written responses, essays, and examination scripts from CBSE English courses to assess the coherence, logical flow, and depth of analysis achieved through structured writing. The study also reviewed how this approach aligns with NEP 2020's focus on enhancing language, analytical, and writing competencies among learners.

Results

Our findings indicate that the general-to-specific writing technique significantly enhances students' ability to express ideas clearly, logically, and coherently. Writing from a general perspective before narrowing down to specific details helps in establishing context, improving retention, and strengthening arguments. It enables learners to connect broad concepts with concrete examples, thus making their writing more persuasive and academically sound.

The study also reveals that this technique benefits students not only at the school level but throughout their academic and professional journey. While in school, it supports the development of foundational skills such as organization, clarity, and critical thinking; beyond school, it equips students with the analytical and linguistic competence necessary for higher education and professional writing.

Key benefits

1. **Structured and logical flow**
   Beginning with a general statement and gradually progressing toward specific details ensures clarity, logical coherence, and reader engagement across disciplines and age groups.

2. **Improved argumentation and critical thinking**
   Students learn to develop well-organized arguments, move from theory to evidence, and think critically about connections between ideas – skills that remain valuable in university and research writing.

3. **Clarity in explanation**
   Complex concepts are made more accessible when writers introduce general overviews before discussing detailed examples, a technique equally useful in literature, science, law, or social studies.

4. **Effective preparation for higher education**
   The general-to-specific approach builds the foundation for academic essay writing, thesis development, and research-based argumentation, thereby easing the transition from school to university studies.

5. **Alignment with educational policy**
   NEP 2020 emphasizes the need to train students in structured and coherent writing methods to enhance their analytical and critical reasoning abilities – a goal directly supported by this technique.

In essence, the general-to-specific writing technique nurtures lifelong writing and reasoning skills. Students who learn to apply it in school are better prepared to write effectively in higher education, competitive examinations, and professional fields that demand structured thinking and clear expression.

Discussion

These findings reinforce the importance of structured writing. In scientific writing, general theories precede specific experiments. Business reports present market overviews before company-specific data. Essay writing benefits from thesis statements followed by supporting arguments. NEP 2020 emphasizes structured writing to develop clear articulation and logical reasoning.

Examples from CBSE literature texts

1. From *Lost Spring* by Anees Jung
   Q: What social issues does the story highlight?
   Ans: (General to specific)
   Kailash Satyarthi, social activist and Nobel laureate says, "Give a child love, laughter, and peace, not child labour." India being a country with the largest youth population in the world must preserve, train, and use this important human resource. Child labour is a curse not only for the poor, but for the entire society.

   The story *Lost Spring* highlights the issues of poverty and child labour in India. It describes how children like Saheb and Mukesh are deprived of basic education and forced into exploitative labour due to financial hardships. Saheb, a rag picker in Seemapuri, dreams of a better life but is trapped in a cycle of poverty, while Mukesh, a child labourer in the bangle-making industry, aspires to break free from this generational occupation.

2. From *Two Gentlemen of Verona* by A.J. Cronin
   Q: What qualities of the two boys, Nicola and Jacopo, impress the narrator?
   Ans: (General to specific)
   Hard work, responsibility, and selflessness are qualities that define truly noble individuals. Eric Berne, a Canadian psychiatrist, in his famous theory of the Three Ego States says that a person displays specific traits not because of their age but because of the way they perceive their life. Similarly, a person displays maturity not because they have attained a certain age, but because of how they handle their life.

Nicola and Jacopo, despite their young age, display remarkable dedication and perseverance. They take on various odd jobs – selling newspapers, polishing shoes, and running errands – not for personal gain but to support their ailing sister, Lucia. Their quiet determination and unwavering sense of duty deeply impress the narrator.

Conclusion

The general-to-specific technique enhances clarity, coherence, and engagement in academic writing. It fosters logical reasoning and analytical skills, as emphasized by NEP 2020. Future research could explore its effectiveness across learning styles and writing formats. In addition to structured writing, appropriate vocabulary and sentence construction are crucial for impactful answers.

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As educators in India, we understand the incredible diversity that fills our classrooms. From bustling metropolitan spaces to those in quieter regions, our students bring with them a wealth of languages, cultures, and individual experiences. This vibrant mix, while enriching, also presents a unique challenge: how do we ensure that every student has a fair chance to demonstrate their understanding, particularly in subjects like mathematics?

The concept of equitable assessment offers a powerful lens through which we can address this challenge. It's crucial to understand that equitable assessment isn't about treating every student the *same* (equal assessment). Instead, it's about providing what each student *needs* at the right time and in the right way to truly showcase their learning (Kampen, 2020). Think of it like providing different-sized shoes to children – everyone gets a pair, but the size is tailored to fit each individual comfortably.

Why is equitable assessment so vital in middle school?

Our classrooms are incredibly diverse, encompassing variations in race, ethnicity, gender, sexual orientation, language, culture, religion, and varying mental and physical abilities (NEA, n.d.). In math classrooms, this diversity manifests in numerous ways:

- **Language diversity:** While many students may be proficient in English or Hindi, some may be more comfortable learning and expressing themselves in their regional languages. Word problems, in particular, can become significant hurdles due to language complexity rather than mathematical understanding (Siegel, M.A., 2007).

Equitable assessments

Monica Kochar

- **Cultural context:** The examples and scenarios we use in math problems might resonate more with some students than others based on their cultural experiences.
- **Learning style and pace:** Students learn at different speeds and through different modalities. Some might grasp concepts quickly through abstract reasoning, while others may benefit from visual aids or hands-on activities.
- **Prior knowledge and access to resources:** Students come with varying levels of prior mathematical knowledge and may have different levels of support and resources outside the classroom.
- **Specific learning needs:** Some students may have learning disabilities or other challenges that require specific accommodations to participate fully in assessments.

Ignoring these differences can lead to assessments that inadvertently measure factors other than mathematical understanding, creating barriers for students and not providing a true picture of their abilities. This is where the principles of equitable assessment become indispensable.

Images generated using AI.

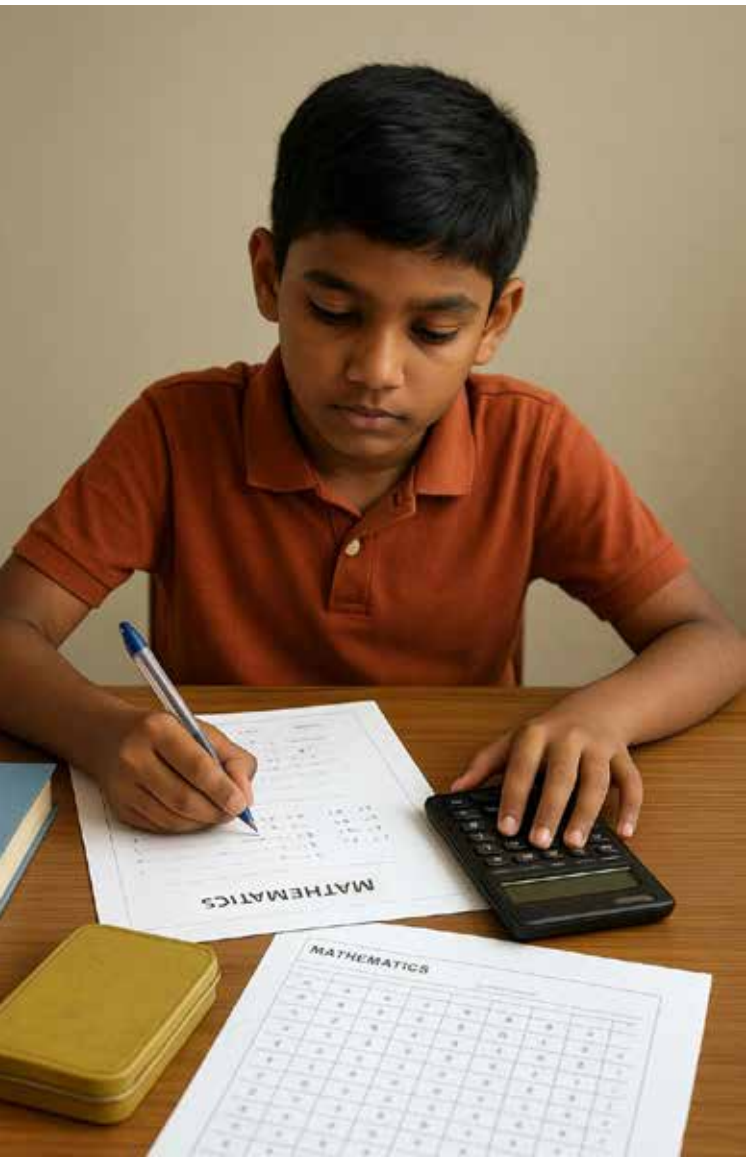
Practical strategies

While various frameworks exist, the core idea revolves around adapting our teaching and assessment methods to meet the diverse needs of our learners (Siegel et al., 2008). Here are some practical strategies we can implement in middle school math classrooms:

Comprehension: making the language accessible

Ensuring students understand what is being asked of them is paramount. In a diverse classroom, this means paying close attention to the language used in assessments.

- Strategy: Simplify language in word problems. Instead of complex sentence structures and unfamiliar vocabulary, use clear and concise language.
  - Example: Instead of: "The sum of the digits of a two-digit number is 9. If 27 is added to the number, the digits are reversed. Find the number."
  - Consider: "A two-digit number has digits that add up to 9. If you add 27 to this number, the order of the digits flips. What is the original number?" (Using simpler phrasing and breaking down the information).



- Strategy: Provide visual aids. Diagrams, pictures, and bar models can help students visualize the problem and reduce reliance on strong language comprehension.
  - Example: For a problem involving ratios like "The ratio of boys to girls in a class is 3:2. If there are 12 boys, how many girls are there?", a bar model with 3 units representing boys and 2 units representing girls can visually demonstrate the relationship.

Elicitation: allowing diverse ways to show understanding

Designing tasks that allow all students to demonstrate their knowledge in ways that suit their strengths.

- Strategy: Offer varied response formats. Instead of solely relying on written answers, consider incorporating oral explanations, visual representations, or even short demonstrations where appropriate.
  - Example: When assessing understanding of angle properties, students could be asked to draw and label different types of angles or explain the relationship between complementary and supplementary angles verbally, instead of just writing their definitions.
- Strategy: Break down complex problems. Large, multi-step problems can be overwhelming. Breaking them into smaller, manageable parts with clear instructions for each step can help students approach the problem systematically.
  - Example: When solving a problem involving profit and loss with multiple steps (calculating cost price, selling price, discount, profit percentage), provide guiding questions for each step: "What is the original cost price?", "What is the selling price after the discount?", "Calculate the profit amount.", "What is the profit percentage?"

Scaffolding: providing temporary support

Provide temporary support structures that help students access the assessment and demonstrate their learning. These supports are gradually removed as students become more proficient.

- Strategy: Offer sentence starters and graphic organizers. These tools can provide a framework for students to organize their thoughts and express their understanding.

- Example: For a problem requiring a written explanation of the Pythagorean theorem, provide sentence starters like: "In a right-angled triangle, the square of the...", or a graphic organizer with sections for identifying the hypotenuse, the other two sides, and the formula.

- Strategy: Provide easier practice questions. Before a formal assessment, offering a set of simpler problems that focus on the core concepts can build confidence and allow students to solidify their understanding.
  - Example: Before assessing the concept of solving linear equations, provide practice problems involving single-step equations like $x+5=10$ or $2y=12$.

Accommodation: adjusting for specific needs

Making necessary adjustments to the assessment process or environment to address the specific needs of students with disabilities or other learning challenges.

- Strategy: Allow extra time. Students who need more time to process information or complete tasks should be provided with it.
- Strategy: Provide a comfortable space. Ensuring a quiet and comfortable environment can reduce anxiety and help students focus better during assessments.
- Strategy: Permit the use of tools. Depending on the student's needs, this might include calculators for complex computations, manipulatives for visual learners, or assistive technology for students with specific learning disabilities. Allowing the use of a bilingual dictionary can be crucial for students who are still developing their proficiency in the language of instruction.

Student agency and collaboration: empowering learners

Empowering students to take ownership of their learning and learn from each other.

- Strategy: Encourage peer help. Collaborative learning can help students clarify their understanding through discussion and different perspectives.
  - Example: During a problem-solving activity, encourage students to work in pairs to understand the problem and discuss potential solution strategies before attempting it individually.
- Strategy: Offer choices in assessment presentation. For projects or more open-ended tasks, allow students to choose how they want to present their findings (e.g., written report, presentation with diagrams, a short skit demonstrating the concept). This caters to different learning styles and strengths. For instance, when exploring data handling, some students might prefer to present their analysis in a written report with charts, while others might create a short presentation explaining their findings visually.

Conclusion

By intentionally incorporating these strategies, we can move towards creating more equitable learning environments in middle school math classrooms. This not only ensures fairer assessments but also fosters a sense of belonging and empowers all students to reach their full mathematical potential. The journey towards equitable assessment is an ongoing process. It requires continuous reflection, learning, and adaptation to the diverse needs of our students. By embracing these principles, we can create classrooms where every student feels seen, supported, and has the opportunity to shine in their mathematical journey.

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More about federal structures – local self-government

Prakash Iyer

Ira: We have been talking a lot about the complexities of federalism in the Indian constitution. But, I am not able to get a complete picture of the implications of federalism in India. I have also heard that our being colonized by the British and their ideas of democracy being imposed on us were the primary problems the Constituent Assembly was fighting. This is why I had raised the question of post-colonialism and how the Constitution was influenced by social and political realities of those times.

Anubhuti: Your question has two parts to it – the incoherence in the nature of federalism in India, and whether our constitution mirrors British ideas alone, or if we re-invoked institutions that existed in the pre-colonial times.

Our constitution is federal but veers towards unitarianism, which we have spoken about already. The powers to individual state governments are quite limited. Even financial powers are shared between the union and state governments. Another more complex issue is *asymmetric federalism*. So far, we have only been talking about the states and the Union of India. We also have other structural entities such as the union territories, which are directly ruled by the central government; some states also have special autonomy, like Jammu and Kashmir through article 370; which has now been revoked. There is the 5th and 6th Schedule in the Constitution, which focuses on regions that have a significantly high tribal population, who have specific primary concerns like laws that govern how land, forests, and mountains are managed, and even laws that govern marriages and inheritance. These Schedules are applied to various regions and populations in Andhra Pradesh, Meghalaya, Assam, Tripura, and Mizoram. There are other states that are fighting for addition to the Schedule, so that the local councils and governors have more authority on the laws and policies made in these regions.

Overall, the asymmetry in our federalism is by design. It has been introduced primarily to take care of the diversity in India, and to protect minorities who have special concerns.

Ira: Just when I thought this is as complex as democracy can get, you introduce me to more complexities I am not even aware of, living here in Bengaluru.

Anubhuti: These laws may not apply directly to us, but the principles on which the Constitution is based influences the way we see the laws that apply to us too. Local self-government is a very good example of what I am trying to say.

Remember you mentioned how the structures in India should be seen like a matrix, where power is distributed both vertically and horizontally? Power distribution does not end with bicameral legislatures. It goes all the way down to local institutions we interact with on a daily basis – municipal corporations, zilla parishads, village panchayats – all of which have different names and terms in different states.

The point I am making is that our Constitution is structured to take democratic power as close to each individual as possible.

Ira: That is interesting. Is this an example of what I was asking earlier – whether pre-colonial institutions were brought back after the British left? Or is there a complicated story here too?

Anubhuti: Ha ha ha. Yes there is. Let me begin with some entertaining quotes. The idea of a postcolonial society itself is complicated. It is a *pejorative term*, which indicates that once colonized, a society remains colonized because some sections of the society inherit the thinking of the colonizer, along with traces of thinking like the colonized. In India, a popular example is the respect we give to the English language and people who speak English – like you and me.

Manish Jain* says the British left India, but the notion of an ideal citizen they created in their civics textbooks, got converted into English-speaking middle-class Indians. But, at the same time, we

*Jain, M. (2005). *Past and present in the curriculum*. Mumbai: Economic and Political Weekly.

# of governance

rejected numerous ideas the British mentioned in the Government of India Act 1935 – including the principles of democracy based on freedom and equality, which they inherited from liberal thinkers like John Stuart Mill and Jeremy Bentham. Like Upendra Baxi† eloquently said, there are always continuities and discontinuities in postcolonial societies.

Ira: Why does he say discontinuities? It seems strange to say that.

Anubhuti: Of course he doesn't stop there. The statement he made, which I like is, *"Constitutions are constructed, as moral autobiographies of "new" nations, promising a new future, vigorously disinvesting the colonial past."* He further argues that constitutionalism and colonialism are antithetical to each other. When we gave ourselves this Indian constitution in 1950, we created a rupture with the past. It is a moral statement we made when a new identity of India was created.

Ira: Moral autobiography of a nation! It is such a profound statement – calling the Constitution a moral document. This is interesting also because it draws a thin line between seeing the Constitution from two extreme viewpoints – a sacred document that cannot be altered and a pliant document that can be changed at will. Why is the local self-government an example of this rupture?

Anubhuti: India had had village councils – panchayats – for centuries. It even continued in some form during the times of the Mughal Empire. Of course, the council members were not elected like they are today, but there was a system in place at the village/town level.

The Montague-Chelmsford reforms in 1919 implemented the idea of local governments, but they were controlled by provincial governments. For them, a local government was not about *devolution* of power; rather they were seen as "an instrument of political and popular education" like Lord Ripon said in 1882. Basically, it was just a way to familiarize the Indian polity with the existence of governance structures and to provide them with access to those

†Baxi, Upendra. 2012. 'Postcolonial Legality: A Postscript from India.' *Verfassung Und Recht in Übersee / Law and Politics in Africa, Asia and Latin America* 45, no. 2 (2012): 178-94.

Image generated using AI.

structures for their immediate needs. For the British, this was decentralization not devolution of power.

Ira: This sounds like a corruption of the idea Gandhi proposed in *Hind Swaraj* – that India should be a conglomeration of self-sufficient village republics. Was this seriously considered in the Constituent Assembly debates? It is a beautiful idea, isn't it?

Anubhuti: Beautiful yes, but too idealistic some people thought. This resulted in prolonged debates in the Constituent Assembly, creating two sides. One side had people like K.T. Shah and Arun Chandra Guha who insisted that village panchayats should be the basic units of provincial governments and that they should be financially empowered as well.

On the other side were people, including Dr. Ambedkar, who insisted that individuals should be the basic unit of society and government, and not villages. He argued that villages survived numerous wars, dynasty changes, with little or no influence on the overall nation. He said, "…they have survived through all vicissitudes, may be a fact. But mere survival has no value. The question is on what plane they have survived. … villages are a sink of localism, a den of ignorance, narrow-mindedness, and communalism."‡ Obviously, the issue he was raising is that while Indian culture and traditions survived, it also carried regionalism, parochialism, ethnic divides, casteism, and other ills with little or no attention to the progress of our society. According to him, allowing that level of sovereignty for villages would be disastrous.

This debate reached an impasse and the compromise reached was to change this ideal of village panchayats and local self-government to the Directive Principles of State Policy (Article 40 of the Constitution).

Ira: Wasn't this argument brought back later? We do have local self-governments now. This came as an amendment of the Constitution, didn't it?

Anubhuti: Yes, that is another story. The popular logic brought by Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi was that only 5000 to 6000 people who are members of the Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha, and all state legislatures represented a population of more than 80 crores. If we introduced panchayats across the nation, we would have 700,000 representatives, which was more reasonable for a large population. He also recommended significant devolution of power to the panchayats. But these amendments were rejected in the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha. It was proposed again in different forms by two subsequent governments, but did not achieve success.

Finally, in 1992, these amendments with significant changes – mainly increasing control of the state governments on the panchayats and village councils – was presented to a Joint Parliamentary Committee and finally approved as the 72nd and 73rd amendment.

Ira: You mean the same debate the Constituent Assembly had on the sovereignty of local government continued in the 1990s! How was it resolved then?

Anubhuti: I am not so sure about the details, but it seems to me that the principle of subsidiarity was applied here. According to this principle, elected representatives who function at the level of a state or province are too distant from the daily realities of citizens. Dealing with infrastructural or documentation work with the state happens at very low levels. For example, to complain about bad roads, we have to go to the ward officer or municipal commissioner. Similarly, registration of properties, water supply, and other daily needs are taken care of by local bodies. Therefore, some amount of devolution of power becomes essential so that they can do the work for us. This also involves prioritizing, choosing solutions and these are issues that might have diverse opinions. If the local bodies have sufficient power, at least financially, they could independently do the work. They would also have to be people who represent the views of the population. This is a way to get closer to direct democracy.

But this model also makes a fundamental assumption that social solidarity exists. If some social cohesion did not exist already, it was bound to lead to issues of exclusion – some groups could be excluded based on caste, religion, or even ethnicity. So, some amount of control from the state government becomes essential to avoid such discriminations.

Ira: Which brings us back to Ambedkar's argument of the risk of provincialism and localism. I need to know more about the nature of local government in India and how it is implemented. That will complete our discussion on federalism.

Anubhuti: There is a lot more to say about this; let's take it up next time. It will also bring up questions of minorities protection, which is another salient feature of our constitution.

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‡https://www.constitutionofindia.net/debates/04-nov-1948/#102890

Could our education system be transformed by doing less?

Tulika Verma

As I write this, I am sitting across from a footwear shop. A toddler who seems about two years old and his mother are leaving the shop and coming down the stairs. The toddler slips and lands on his buttocks but gets up right away. His mother, understandably, tries to hold his hand but he pulls away decidedly, and continues to walk down the rest of the stairs on his own, slowly and unsteadily.

I see this and think about the innate agency in children and the dignity they associate with it. They protect it fiercely, asking through their actions, for the space to make their own mistakes and learn from them. I feel the same fierce sense of wanting to assert my agency as a 36-year old woman, and in my 84-year old grandmother, who, much like the toddler, sometimes stumbles a bit when she walks, but only extends a hand to ask for support when most needed.

If this desire for agency is so innate to human beings, why have we created an education system that strips children and adults alike of it? Why have we created classrooms that require children to be passive vessels where knowledge must be poured from the outside rather than acknowledge them as living, breathing beings who have an innate curiosity and capacity to learn? Why have we created education systems where teachers and others in the hierarchy all feel a sense of helplessness – that they must comply, must do what they are being asked to do?

The answers to many of these questions lie in the violent, colonial legacy of the education system as we know it. It is a system that defines the purpose of education as employability – an extremely low standard for a process as sacred and innate to the human experience as learning. It fails repeatedly in that low objective too, as ASER reports or national employability surveys will show you. It is based on a view of human beings as 'resources' for an industrial system that benefits a few. Therefore, it fails to see our humanity. On the one hand, it creates a sense of 'each one for themselves' as reinforced by the relentless focus on competition, minimizing the focus on developing our ability to collaborate and co-create. On the other, it suppresses, with an iron hand, individual creativity and independent thinking, by mandating singular 'right' answers and ways of doing things.

There have been many attempts to 'correct' this system. Usually, motivated by the desire to improve the employability outcome, and therefore, test scores and attendance, these attempts usually lead to doing more of the same. The thinking is – let's train teachers more, let's mandate more things. The assumption is often that teachers are either lazy or incompetent or both, and that children have no agency. As a result, teachers all over the country feel the burden of frequent trainings and tools they didn't ask for, which they feel don't work in their contexts, but feel pressured to engage in. A process like this is bound to lead to disengagement.

What then is the way forward? As I frame this question, I want to take into account not just the past and present of our country and the world, but also the future. We stand at a crossroads in history where the human tendency to keep consuming and doing more has led to a multi-dimensional crisis. The climate crisis, depletion of planetary resources, rapidly growing inequality, wars, the mental health and loneliness epidemic, are all signs of failing systems. According to the 2023-24 UNDP Human Development Report, about half of the world's population does not feel in control of their own life. Over 70% feel that they have no say in how larger political and social decisions are taken. What then is the way forward for education in this context? What world are our learners inheriting? What relationship are they building with the human and non-human world? What beliefs are they inheriting about their own ability to create a new reality for themselves

and the world? What is the purpose of education in this world that so direly needs healing? Is it enough to continue to aim loosely and ineffectively for individual employability?

If our collective wellbeing could be the central pursuit of education, we would begin to see that children are not only innately capable of learning, but it is their way of life. Learning is not something that happens only in classrooms. Children are always observing, experimenting, pushing boundaries, making meaning and learning, both individually and with each other. Our role as educators then, perhaps, is not to make them learn, but to remove barriers along this natural path of learning.

I have been a lover and an observer of the natural world all my life, both the human and the more than human world. I feel that the non-human world has much to teach us about sustained growth and resilience. It offers powerful metaphors that can simplify complex human phenomena. Permaculture is a beautiful example of experimenting with organic growth. A permaculture farmer does not look at a piece of land and ask, "What do I want to grow here?" Instead, she asks, "What grows here?" This shift allows her to not treat the land like a lifeless thing that must be filled with pesticides and fertilizers. It allows her to be in connection with the innate nature of the land and know that the most natural thing for it to do is to grow things. So she plants species that are native to that land, and sees her role as one who fosters this innate capacity. She ensures that there is water and sunlight, and then she sees the magic that happens in the land on its own. When nurtured in a way that is most natural to it, the land begins to regenerate. New species of plants and insects arrive. A self-balancing ecosystem is created where pesticides are not needed. Whatever dies is returned to the land as compost, so no external fertilizer is needed. The farmer's effort is greatly reduced. Her role is to sense the need and then to respond to that need by removing barriers in the natural process of growth.

Illustration: Tanaya Vyas

What if children as well as adults are also living systems capable of this growth on their own? What if the role of teachers is to trust the child's innate capacity for growth, notice what their natural tendencies are and just remove barriers that get in the way of that growth? What if the only capacity we need to build at all levels in the education system is one of trust in each other's agency and capacity?

"This is all well and good. But I work in a system that expects outcomes. I can't just let go of those," is a sentiment I often hear in my work with people in the education system. In fact, when we go deeper, this feeling is articulated as, "If I had my way, I would do things differently but I have pressure from those above me to operate in a certain way." This sentiment, ironically, is echoed by teachers, school leaders, education officers, all the way to the top. Parents feel a similar pressure from the society around them. The little shoulders of our children carry all this pressure. However, when we pause and try to understand this 'pressure from above', we realize that it is felt at all levels of the education system, by all the people who are the system. There is a sense of learned helplessness, a lack of agency that we have normalized in this system.

What can be done then? Maybe that is not the right question. Maybe the right question is, *what must we stop doing?* I will not offer prescriptions, because top-down prescriptions by people removed from the ground is at the very heart of the problems that plague this system. However, I will invoke a dream. What if we paused and took a deep collective breath? What if we came together in local communities of children, parents, teachers, non-teaching staff, school leaders and simply *listened* to the experiences of our children? What if we asked ourselves what we could stop doing or do less of, and how we could ease the burden of our violent expectations? What if we committed to co-creating with the students every learning experience, every school structure, every policy that impacts them? What if classrooms became playgrounds of imagination for students, where the teacher senses the unique potential of each child and responds to it? What if we can collectively serve teachers to bring their most grounded, compassionate selves into classrooms so that they can *listen* better? What if every child begins to have an ecosystem around her that trusts her and her desire for learning and commits to clearing pathways to her growth?

Imagine how much more harmonious the education system can become if we saw it as a living, breathing system capable of reaching great potential if we stopped filling it with excess.

Tulika Verma is a writer, facilitator, and leadership coach whose work sits at the intersection of education and systems change. She is the founder of *Sahaj Collective*, where she supports leaders and communities to reimagine how we live, learn, and work together – shifting from extractive ways of organizing to more compassionate and regenerative ones. A former City Director at Teach For India, Tulika now designs learning journeys, coaches leaders, and writes on themes of agency, community, and the deep transformation of systems that shape our lives. To know more about her and the work she does visit tulikaverma.com and sahajcollective.org.

Are kids' newspapers obsolete in the era of doomscrolling?

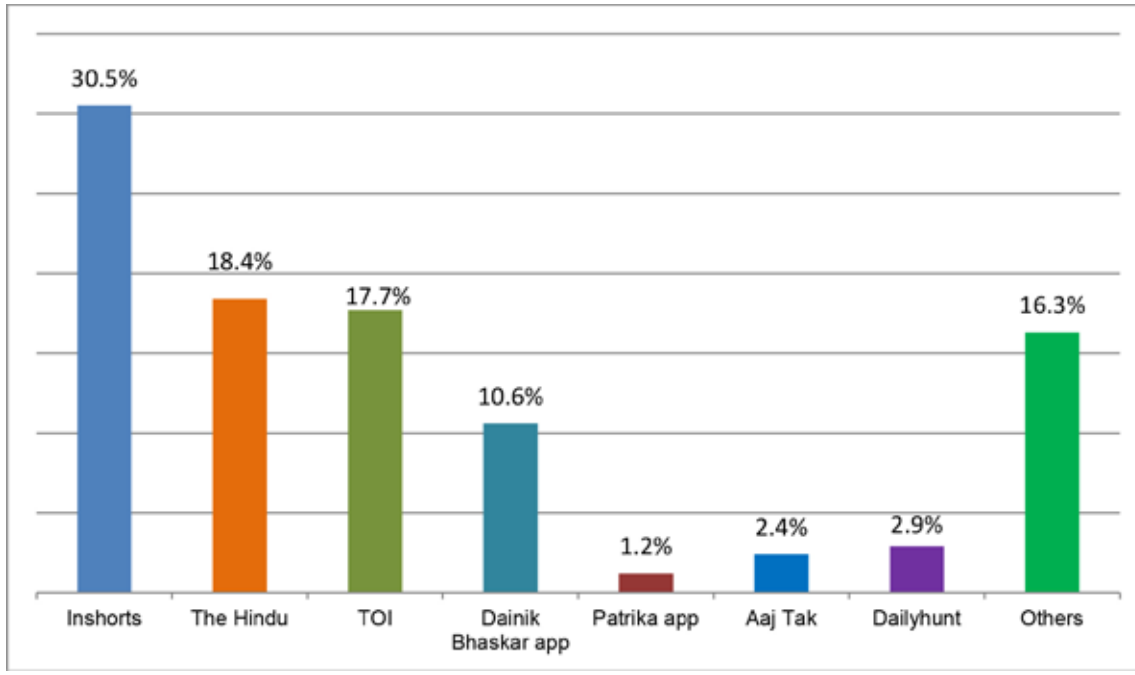
Sanjhee Gianchandani

A recent interaction between the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh, Yogi Adityanath, and the toppers of class 10 and 12 in Lucknow revealed two interesting things – he asked them if they read newspapers which first revealed that not only them, but students in classes 8 and 9 studying in prestigious English-medium schools across the country also do not read the newspaper but might skim through the headlines once in a while. Second, even if they read the newspapers, they focus on the puzzles. Let's try to investigate the reasons behind this.

A newspaper is defined as a publication that is usually issued daily, weekly, or at other regular times and provides news, views, features, and other information of public interest. Since the blessed newspaper has forerunners dating back to 17th century England, a majority of people believe that it is the Bible of literary and political opinion and the most reliable source of news and information, providing comprehensive coverage of both local events and global issues. But today, when we are sitting on the brink of the 22nd century in a world that is fast-paced and technology-driven, is reading the printed newspaper still relevant if the only objective is to remain abreast with current affairs? We all know the answer: it is unequivocally, 'no'.

Both school-going children and the adults in their ecosystems have increasingly moved away from reading newspapers, opting instead to stay informed through online news or by receiving headline updates via news apps on their phones. Here are some findings from an independent research survey* conducted with 200 Gen Z individuals, from both rural and urban areas, regarding their preferred methods for reading the news every morning.

*Tandon Vijay, Nema Devanshi, and Saini Ajay Kumar (July 2023) From Print to Pixel: Analysis of Perception of Gen Z Towards Sustainability in Print and Online News Formats , *Korea Review Of International Studies, Volume 16* (Special Issue 06) Page 113-126.



This could be the case for several reasons:

1. **Accessibility:** There are apps available for almost all newspapers in India, be it *The Times of India, The Hindustan Times, The Hindu* or even regional newspapers such as *Punjab Kesari* or *Asomiya Pratidin*. News on these apps can be read conveniently anytime, anywhere, unlike physical copies, which can be consumed only at specific locations.
2. **Cost-effectiveness:** Producing digital content is generally cheaper than print media. This allows digital media platforms to offer more content at lower or no cost to readers. Therefore, we can see a post-pandemic shift to relying on online news portals. Sumitra Rawat, whose three daughters are studying in classes 6, 8, and 10 in a local school, admitted, "In the pandemic, my husband's salary was reduced and prices went up. We had to cut corners, and we stopped buying newspapers."
3. **Interactivity:** We must not forget that our students belong to Gen Alpha and now Gen Beta. They are used to dynamic reading on social media, which has an array of interactive features such as videos, hyperlinks, sharing options, buttons for reactions, and comment sections. This makes the reading of updates a much more engaging activity when compared to the static nature of the printed newspaper.
4. **Personalization:** Since the advent of AI, it is very easy to access content that is tailored to one's preferences. This applies to news items as well. The articles we engage with online can generate similar ones and satiate our topics of interest, whereas in print media, we have to go with a one-size-fits-all approach.
5. **Environmental impact:** On the surface, digital media is more environmentally friendly and produces a less-intensive carbon footprint as compared to their print counterparts. The carbon footprint of a newspaper depends on a host of factors – production, printing and transport, whether the consumer recycles it after use, and so on. According to a report published in *The Guardian*: At the highest end of the spectrum, purchasing seven bulky papers each week, all of them printed on typical paper stock and ultimately sent to landfill, could create as much as a tonne of CO_2 emissions each year. That's comparable to two short-haul flights!

While it is established that adults have shifted to accessing news digitally, what options do students in India have? Mainstream newspapers that adults used to read exhaustively contain mature and sensitive content, which is not suitable for children. These newspapers often cover topics such as politics, crime, global conflicts, or economic issues, which may be irrelevant to the day-to-day lives of school-going children. Moreover, they may begin to feel anxious and encumbered after reading these narratives. Also, the tone of writing is often caustic, serious, dry, and incisive, which may not sit well with young minds who are accustomed to reading engaging, crisp, and positive writing in their school textbooks and even their leisure reading. This is where one would expect children's newspapers to step in. By way of design, these should provide a selection of news items that are appropriate for children. Articles need to be rewritten in a way that resonates with children's perspectives, ensuring the content is relatable and accessible. The information should be presented in a balanced, unbiased manner, free from complex jargon or controversial themes.

Providing a mix of educational, entertaining, and culturally relevant topics can help young readers understand the world around them in a way that fosters curiosity while promoting critical thinking and empathy. Newspapers must maintain their core purpose of 'informing' readers, rather than turning them into mere supplementary activity books. They should prioritize delivering relevant, factual, and timely news, helping children develop their unique worldviews. While activities may be included, they should never dwarf the primary goal of news reporting – arming young readers with knowledge, nurturing critical thinking, and promoting awareness of current events.

Let's look at a few children's newspapers available in India with their advantages and disadvantages listed for a comparative analysis.

Newspaper	Pros	Cons
Kids Age	Monthly Print – subscription (INR 1695 annually) Digital – free Segments catering to different age groups. Innovative editions to break monotony.	No trial period subscription available; may not be affordable for everyone. No sample copies available for parents/teachers to view before subscribing. Limited to students till grade 8. May offer over-simplified opinions on some topics.
Robin Age	Fortnightly (20 pages of news and knowledge + 12 pages of activity-based learning) Print – subscription (INR 2399 annually + digital free) Digital – subscription (INR 99 annually) News and information that is relevant to school curricula and projects (English, maths, science, general knowledge, and values). Interactive, informative, positive, and engaging content, which aims at encouraging reading.	Fortnightly editions do not allow for effective routines to be formed. Sometimes, the editions may not reach on time. May not engage all age-groups equally, especially middle and senior-school students. It resembles an extended workbook or project book, requiring students to interpret and derive meaning from the content on their own. May not cover niche or important topics in detail.
Times NIE	Daily; most popular newspaper for students in India. A tailored newspaper designed specifically for students, offering content that enhances learning and supports classroom discussions; carefully curated to be both relevant and current, enriching students' educational experiences by providing valuable insights and fostering critical thinking.	Limited interactive or multimedia content, which can make it less engaging for visual learners. Its focus on mainstream topics might limit the scope of content that engages every student, particularly those with niche or specialized interests. Additionally, its content could feel more like supplementary material than a comprehensive educational tool.
Hindu Young World Club	Weekly E-paper format only; downloadable as a PDF as a replica of the newspaper. Subscription – INR 349 annually / INR 199 for 6 months; 14-day free trial period available. Content focused towards exam preparation, explainer articles, and vocabulary improvement guides.	Dependent on regular subscriptions and payments. The absence of a print version may limit the tactile experience of holding a physical copy, which many readers still find enjoyable. May overwhelm kids with too much visual and interactive stimulation.
The Children's Newspaper	Thrice a week Print – subscription (INR 2700 annually) Digital – subscription (INR 1799 annually) This newspaper provides a simple, focused experience, helping them engage with news in a clear, digestible way without distractions.	Kids may risk losing interest if there isn't a steady flow of new articles or updates to keep them coming back. Difficult for older or more advanced readers to find challenging material that piques their interest or encourages deeper learning.
Junior Age	Fortnightly Print – subscription (INR 2400 annually) Digital – subscription (INR 1800 annually) Mix of local and world news, sports news, and climate news in a child-friendly and age-appropriate manner. Offers writing internships to aspiring young journalists aged 14 and above, providing them with hands-on experience.	Unlimited access can lead to excessive screen time and discourage offline activities. The selection of news items could result in content saturation, potentially making it difficult to maintain readers' attention across all issues.

The Curious Owl	Weekly Print – subscription (INR 3150 annually) Digital – subscription (INR 1200 annually) Digital editions also available overseas. Serves as an essential bridge, helping young readers transition smoothly to adult newspapers. It equips them with the skills to read critically and form well-informed opinions.	Infrequent publication may cause readers to lose interest due to a lack of consistency. Some readers may become disengaged, as they may feel they already know what to expect and lack the intrigue that more varied, dynamic content could provide.
Student Edge	Monthly Print – subscription (INR 1500 annually) The only newspaper that addresses senior students, offering content that addresses their academic needs and interests.	Challenges when trying to reach the team regarding shipping and refund-related inquiries. The content may come across as dry and overly factual, lacking engaging elements or interactive features that could captivate the readers' interest.

It does not take a genius educator to realize the value addition made by effective newspapers in a classroom setting. They help in developing reading sub-skills, utilizing zero periods, pointing out printing mistakes, differentiating between facts and opinions, scurrying for specific news items, writing opinion pieces and news reports based on headlines, organizing debates on hot topics, and a plethora of other activities. But the larger question we must ask ourselves is how important it is for us to know what constitutes “news” and whether we need to know everything that is termed as news these days.

Trust in news is falling, with much of the public, especially younger age groups, increasingly turning away from it. The 2022 Reuters Institute Digital News Report found that consumption of traditional news media declined in nearly all the countries surveyed, with online and social consumption of news not making up for it. The proportion of news consumers who say they "avoid news" has risen sharply across countries, with the report describing the phenomenon as "selective avoidance". Reasons for this aversion include being put off by the repetitiveness of the news agenda, being worn out by the news, and not trusting it. So, when this shift is happening, it is happening for kids too. Let’s consider other ways of building reading skills, avoiding excessive screen time, enhancing their levels of curiosity, and engaging in meaningful discussions rather than relying solely on newspapers to do so.

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Deeper into the tamarind grove

Nandini Dholepat

Sitting under the tamarind trees, the students started discussing and writing. After some time, Prabhakar asked them, "I hope you have written down the names of the trees you know. Can you read them out?"

The students started shouting out the names one by one – mango, jackfruit, jamun, neem, coconut, arecanut, millingtonia, jacaranda, banyan, palm, champak, sandalwood, teak, gooseberry….

Prabhakar said, "Ok, collectively this is not more than 20 names. Some of them, like the coconut, grow on cultivated crop land. We are discussing forest trees."

I explained, "The Kodagu district of Karnataka has evergreen forests with high mountain peaks and valleys. Kodagu has more than 200 sacred groves." I listed the names of 87 different types of trees in 21 devarakadus, in addition to small plants and climbers. "The *Neerulli Bana* stretches 532 hectares. Imagine the extent of the forest! I visited *Vanabhadra Kali* grove, one of the largest devarakadus. As the name suggests, *Bhadra Kali* is the goddess guarding that forest. It was spread over 32 hectares. In Kodemangalore, a Bombax ceiba (silk cotton) tree has been found to have a girth of 10m. Sacred groves are home to many endangered flora and fauna. For example, Canarium strictum (dhoop tree) is categorized as a threatened species under the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN). It is on the Red List. Similarly, Malabar civet (Civet cat), endemic to the Western Ghats, is also found in these groves. These forests are close to wildlife reserves. You must have heard about the Nagarhole Tiger Reserve. The deverakadus in Kodagu are part of it. The temples in devarakadu are not always pukka buildings. It may just be a stone, a tree, or sometimes a few terracotta artifacts inside a temple-like structure. However, nowadays you do see contemporary temple structures and proper pathways to some of these temples inside the groves."

One of the students said, "I am from Kerala, *Iringolekavu* is near my village. I had been there with my grandfather during the summer holidays. Here is a photo."

Photos courtesy: Nandini Dholepat

Prabhakar called everyone to attention, "Students, there is a lot more to see here. Let us have some food and then move to the other side of the grove."

The local guard, Muniyappa, came and cautioned us, "Here, monkeys will trouble you. You'd better sit near the temple, where there is a drinking water tap too."

We all crossed the road and sat under the peepal tree by the side of the temple. The college students and our Backyard Group sat together to enjoy food.

Vivan said, "Monkey is staring from a distance, if it comes here, what to do?"

"Monkeys and dogs get scared if they see someone carrying a stick. I am here, your guard. I will chase them away," Muniyappa said.

"Since when have you been guarding this grove?" Anand asked.

"Must be from the past 50-60 years, do not remember, I live nearby," Muniyappa said.

"What do you do with these many tamarind trees? What is the quantity of fruits you collect in a year?" Shalini asked.

"The fruits ripen in the winter season. After that, they will be collected in March and April by the villagers. The collection is auctioned, and the income will be shared among the collectors," Muniyappa said.

"It is good income for the villagers, is it not?"a student asked.

"Yes, do you think humans will conserve anything if they do not find any monetary benefit out of it?" Prabhakar asked.

Sujatha said,"I agree with you sir. Good thought by our ancestors, they developed such a treasure for the future population."

"So, overall, who manages the land? The forest department?" a student asked.

"There you see the signboard installed by the State Biodiversity Board. There is a National Biodiversity Authority (NBA) in India. It is a statutory autonomous body under the Ministry of Environment, Forests, and Climate Change, Government of India, established in 2003. Under that, at the state level, there are State Biodiversity Boards," Prabhakar said.

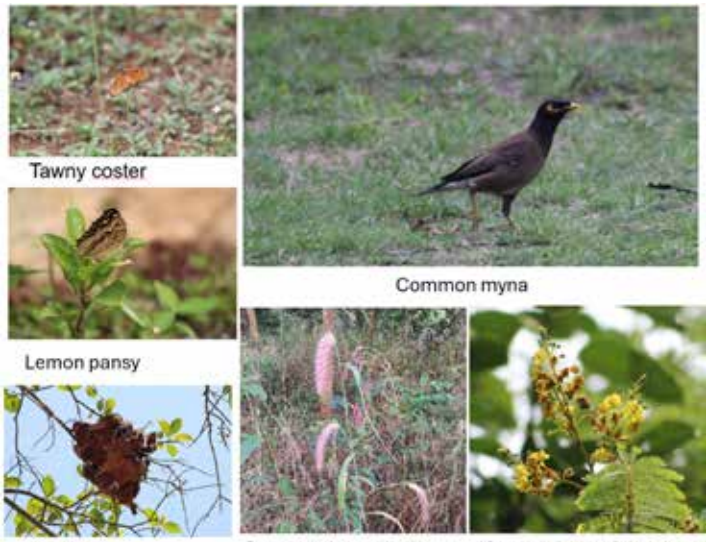
"Can we visit the State Biodiversity Board to learn about their activities?" a student asked.

"Possible. We can also be involved in their work," I replied.

"That's great, how do we approach them and what kind of work can we be involved in?" a student asked.

"If you want to understand how you can help, let us do an activity. Start by dividing yourselves into groups. Say the numbers 1, 2, 3, and 4. Those who said 1 will be in group 'one'. Those who said 2 will be grouped in 'two.' Got it?" I instructed.

Prabhakar said, "Each group should go in a different direction. Write down the names of plants, animals, and insects you see. If you don't know the name, take a picture, or draw a diagram to find out later. You should maintain complete silence when you walk, otherwise, insects and birds will get disturbed and fly away. We will meet back here in half an hour."



Sujatha and Madhavi also went with the groups. After half an hour, all groups returned and started showing the pictures they had taken – butterflies, ant nests, wasps, flowers, grass, etc. The college students were able to identify the plants and birds. Prabhakar helped them identify the butterflies. There were photos of a brown butterfly sitting on the Tridax flower, a Pansy on a milkweed plant, and an ant nest on a tree. The nest was built by bringing the leaves of the tree together. The Backyard Group was happy to see and listen to this information given by the students.

"See the wasp nest. It made a perfect geometry of cells to lay eggs. The bracket-tailed bird is 'Drango,' and the noisy 'Babbler,'" Shalini exclaimed with excitement.

Madhavi showed me a picture, "What are these green net-like threads spread on the bushes? And what about the pink flowers on the other side?"

I called everyone, "Come here and see this picture. Can you guess what this green colour thread spread over this bush is?"

"Some plant roots hanging?" someone asked in a feeble voice. Another student said, "Some waste material thrown on the bushes?"

"Is it some kind of plant growing on the bushes?" Anand asked.

"Good answer. It is a parasitic plant commonly known as Dodder or Cuscuta. It can be identified by its thin stem. The leaves are reduced to minute scales. The Dodder flower ranges from white to pink or cream colours. Some flowers bloom in early summer, others later. Dodder seeds are minute and sprout at or near the surface of the soil. Seed germination can occur without a host plant, but it should reach a green plant quickly. It reaches nearby plants by following chemosensory clues or chemical signals sent out from the host plants," I explained.

Pink flowers-Ipomea. Green net like - *Cuscuta*

A student replied, "The pink flower plant is Ipomoea, which is a climber. It has bulbous roots. I saw one on the roadside on my way home."

"You all identified many small plants, trees, birds, and wasps in a short time and in a small area. Consider your village or town, and the numbers of plants and animals you will find. Proper documentation is required to understand the biodiversity of a place. Apart from this, there may be a river, a pond, or a hillock that hosts different types of plants and animals. To take up a conservation program or plan developmental activities, it is necessary to have a record of the biotic and abiotic components of the place. To do this, people living in a particular place need to prepare a biodiversity register. At the state level, the State Biodiversity Board facilitates the preparation of People's Biodiversity Registers (PBR). Your college can participate in this program. You can help the villagers document and spread awareness on the importance of documenting biodiversity," I explained.

"Sir, when can we be involved in PBR preparation, and whom do we approach?" the students asked. Prabhakar replied, "We need to enquire with the Board, but before that, you must know more about biodiversity and conservation."

Suggested activities

1. Name the avenue side trees near your school.
2. Give examples of chemosensory receptors.

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